

DEVELOPING INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION COMPETENCE



*Lori Halverson-Wente & Mark Halverson-
Wente*

Rochester Community and Technical
College

Developing Intercultural Communication Competence

Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente
Rochester Community and Technical College

This text is disseminated via the Open Education Resource (OER) LibreTexts Project (<https://LibreTexts.org>) and like the thousands of other texts available within this powerful platform, it is freely available for reading, printing, and "consuming."

The LibreTexts mission is to bring together students, faculty, and scholars in a collaborative effort to provide an accessible, and comprehensive platform that empowers our community to develop, curate, adapt, and adopt openly licensed resources and technologies; through these efforts we can reduce the financial burden born from traditional educational resource costs, ensuring education is more accessible for students and communities worldwide.

Most, but not all, pages in the library have licenses that may allow individuals to make changes, save, and print this book. Carefully consult the applicable license(s) before pursuing such effects. Instructors can adopt existing LibreTexts texts or Remix them to quickly build course-specific resources to meet the needs of their students. Unlike traditional textbooks, LibreTexts' web based origins allow powerful integration of advanced features and new technologies to support learning.



LibreTexts is the adaptable, user-friendly non-profit open education resource platform that educators trust for creating, customizing, and sharing accessible, interactive textbooks, adaptive homework, and ancillary materials. We collaborate with individuals and organizations to champion open education initiatives, support institutional publishing programs, drive curriculum development projects, and more.

The LibreTexts libraries are Powered by [NICE CXone Expert](#) and was supported by the Department of Education Open Textbook Pilot Project, the California Education Learning Lab, the UC Davis Office of the Provost, the UC Davis Library, the California State University Affordable Learning Solutions Program, and Merlot. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. 1246120, 1525057, and 1413739.

Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation nor the US Department of Education.

Have questions or comments? For information about adoptions or adaptations contact info@LibreTexts.org or visit our main website at <https://LibreTexts.org>.

The LibreTexts name, logo, and book covers are trademarked by LibreTexts, Inc. (a 501(c)(3) not-for-profit organization) and protected against unauthorized use.

This text was compiled on 08/13/2026

- [InfoPage](#) by [Delmar Larsen](#) is licensed [Public Domain](#).

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Licensing

Introduction

1: Intercultural Communication

- 1.1: Key Intercultural Communication Terms
- 1.2: Intercultural Communication and Cultural Relativism
- 1.3: Perception
- 1.4: Nonverbal Communication
- 1.5: Verbal Communication
- 1.6: Listening

2: Intercultural Communication Interview Essay

- 2.1: Sample Essays
- 2.2: Grading Rubric
- 2.3: Sample Outline 1 – Exploring 3 Different Aspects of a Co-Culture
- 2.4: Sample Outline 2

3: Communicating with Co-Cultures

- 3.1: Guest 1 – Meet Michael and Learn about the LGBTQA+ Community
- 3.2: Guest 2 – Meet Meet Kim Sin and learn about the Cambodian-American Community
- 3.3: Guest 3 – Meet Al Lun and Learn more about being a “Permanent Other”
- 3.4: Guest 3 – Meet Chao Mwatela, RCTC Multicultural Advisor
- 3.6: Guest 5 – Meet Laura, RCTC Student and Human Library Volunteer
- 3.5: Guest 4 – Meet Becca, RCTC Director of Student Rights and Responsibilities/Title IX Coordinator

Index

Glossary

Detailed Licensing

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

Introduction

THE “HUMANS UNIT” OVERVIEW:

The “Humans Unit” is an intercultural communication interview learning module providing students a unique opportunity to better understand a given culture outside of, or other than, their own culture.

The “Humans Unit” Objective:

The interview learning module is foundational for the process of acquiring that level of intercultural communication competence, increasingly necessary for professional growth and personal fulfillment, as it gives students sensitive insight to persons of another culture and an appreciation for one’s role and responsibility within our globalized world. In short, “[c]ollaboration and commerce between nations and across cultures is an unavoidable necessity of modern living, with the success of those endeavors hinged upon the competence with which each party interacts with the other. Further, these interactions can be beneficial, not just in terms of each group realizing their respective goals, but also at the level of the individuals involved” (Cavanaugh, 2015, p.1). Thus, presenting and encouraging the transformative process of learning effective intercultural communication interviewing skills are key to improving intercultural communication competence — the extent to which one is able to “effectively adapt verbal and nonverbal messages to the appropriate cultural context” (Neuliep, 2018, p.37).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com/

Elements of this Unit Include:

Increasing Intercultural Communication Competence is the general objective of this unit. Elements of this unit include theory, sample student work, online class activities, relevant links and resources. The key questions addressed in this learning unit include:

- **What are communication and intercultural communication competence**
- **What is perception and perception checking?**
- **What verbal skills are used in building intercultural communication competence?**
- **What nonverbal skills are used in building intercultural communication competence?**
- **How can compassionate listening help build intercultural communication competence?**

Communication Skill Areas Related to Intercultural Communication:



Rochester Diversity Council Photograph, used with permission

There are four primary concepts and skill areas, central to intercultural communication itself, that are necessary for conducting an intercultural interview—perception and perception-checking, nonverbal communication and verbal communication, listening. The pedagogical format used to best impart the four skill areas central to intercultural interviewing includes a definition of the skill area itself, a discussion of the practice or use of this skill area in intercultural communication contexts, questions to consider for the effective use of the skill area, and a prompt or queue for the development of an essay assignment reflecting upon the intercultural interview; in sum, we consider what is learned from the preparation for the interview, the tenor, and substance of the interview itself, and a reflection upon if/how the interview transforms or deepens an understanding of both the culture of the interviewee as

well as the student's own culture. The unit is peppered throughout with insightful student observations and, in the appendix, helpful comments culled from past student papers are offered. External resources, class activities, and videos will also be provided for an opportunity to further and deepen understanding of the four skill areas (perception, verbal and non-verbal communication, and listening) beyond what is strictly necessary for the scope of the student essay.

Course Content:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Though designed to assist in reviewing and distilling certain key conceptual and skill areas relevant to the essay assignment, this unit still stresses familiarity with primary course materials as a whole or related/important material covered during class. Course content must be read carefully, understanding the importance of asking the instructor for clarification of something unclear, addressing any questions that occur while reading, or sharing valuable student life-experience with the instructor, sparked by reading or conversation, that may inform or flavor the essay. The instructor will do everything possible to help the student succeed in both understanding the concepts and formulating a solid outline or strategy for using core concepts in the intercultural interview. The instructor will help the student translate what they have learned of the theoretical aspects of intercultural communication, what they have experienced in a successfully conducted interview process, and, drawing from the student's personal experience itself, offer suggestions as to thinking through and writing a coherent narrative that shows progress towards intercultural communication/interviewing competence. Again, sample outlines, previous student essays, and other helpful resources are linked at the end of this unit.

Resources Include:

- **Sample Student Work**
- **Sample Assignments and Activities**
- **Resources**
 - **Human Library Links**
 - **Video Suggestions**
 - **Additional Related Intercultural Communication Open Education Resources**

About the Project – Contact Us:



Lori and Mark Halverson-Wente

This project was funded with a generous Professional Development Grant from [Education Minnesota](https://education.mn.gov) and is the first phase of, what we hope will become, a full Open Educational Resource (OER) textbook written by Mark and Lori Halverson-Wente.

Feedback on this OER book can be sent to lori.halverson-wente@rctc.edu or mhalversonwente@gmail.com.

Resources were used, with correct attribution, from the OER textbooks: hopen.lib.umn.edu/communication and <https://introtocommopen.source.ridgewater.edu/>. Sources for media are attributed with the graphic, photo, audio, or video. A comprehensive listing of attributes can be found in the Works Cited Page in the Appendix section of this WordPress Book.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Intercultural Communication

- 1.1: Key Intercultural Communication Terms
- 1.2: Intercultural Communication and Cultural Relativism
- 1.3: Perception
- 1.4: Nonverbal Communication
- 1.5: Verbal Communication
- 1.6: Listening

This page titled [1: Intercultural Communication](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente](#) and [Mark Halverson-Wente](#) (Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

1.1: Key Intercultural Communication Terms

Defining Key Terms

“We may have all come on different ships, but we’re in the same boat now.”

—attributed to Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. in a speech by Rep. John Lewis commemorating the 50th anniversary of the march on Washington D.C. (Washington Post, August 28, 2013).

Chapter Summary:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

This chapter reviews many of the primary concepts related to intercultural communication in general and, in particular, defines and explores those concepts/skills most closely correlated to interviewing and student intercultural communication competence.

Understanding the standard definitions of terms and concepts within the discipline of Communication will help you write your essay. Note within your primary textbook and see the resource section for links to additional online materials. Terms to consider exploring in your preparation and/or essay include: communication; culture and selected components of culture (e.g. deep structure, cultural patterns and typologies); cultural identity; intercultural communication; perception, cultural values and beliefs; listening (compassionate listening necessary to provide the awareness and practical wherewithal for conducting an intercultural communication interview); uncertainty reduction; and finally, intercultural communication competence and the sojourner experience, consisting of motivation, possessing knowledge to draw upon, effectively exercising communication skills drawn from the terms and concepts above, and understanding the importance of the context in which one exercises these skills.



Photo from the Rochester, MN Diversity Council, used with permission

While the “Humans Unit” will include both skill-based and theoretical aspects and applications, it is hoped that students will, as a result of the process described above, gradually become a culturally curious, confident and competent communicator in a wide variety of intercultural communication encounters. Now, once gained, intercultural competencies may be deepened and tested through travel, perhaps contributing in a profound sense to an authentic sojourner experience, discussed below. It is a brute fact that one semester in the classroom, while perhaps necessary, is simply not sufficient to learn with full substance or depth the vast set of various life skills necessary to effectively function in a different culture or navigate our globe’s diverse cultures; that is, the classroom cannot be the sole path to progress in one’s ability to successfully navigate our common village of cultural variety brought about, for good or ill, by the forces of globalization. Likewise, a strictly scripted set of activities by a ship’s cruise director may bring you closer to another mammalian culture, such as swimming with the dolphins, but could ignore the authentic human culture found but a mile or two away from the Disney floating behemoths in ports of call such as the Bahamas, Jamaica, etc.

Communication Defined:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Communication loosely means “sharing and understanding meaning” or to “make common” (Pearson & Nelson, 2000). Community and communication share the same root word and, in “making common,” we find a means to use verbal (words) and nonverbal (non-words) symbols to reduce uncertainty.

Defining communication is difficult; however, the goal of human communication is simply to share and understand the same meaning. Professor Schultze puts it straightforwardly: “If you don’t understand what I am actually intending to say, we failed to communicate. Such lack of shared understanding is miscommunication, not communication” (Schultze, n.d.). Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy (2017) posit that “...human communication is a dynamic process in which people attempt to share their thoughts with other people through the use of symbols in particular settings” (p.28).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

In intercultural settings, the communicators might not share the same language. Therefore, **nonverbal communication** takes on an additional emphasis. “Nonverbal communication is a process of generating meaning using behavior other than words. Rather than thinking of nonverbal communication as the opposite of or as separate from verbal communication, it’s more accurate to view them as operating side by side—as part of the same system” (Communication, 2016, p.165).

All communication happens within a context or communication situation. When the context includes individuals from different cultures, there is a unique potential for both uncertainty, but also room for growth as the communicators learn from one another. Examining the definition of culture assists in this growth.

Culture Defined:

Culture is communication and communication is culture ~ E. T. Hall (1959)



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Defining **culture** can be imprecise; there are hundreds of academic definitions each of which highlight a different aspect or nuance to suit their own particular approach. Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy (2017) explain, “Culture is a set of human-made objective and subjective elements that in the past have increased the probability of survival and resulted in satisfaction for the participants in an ecological niche, and thus became shared among those who could communicate with each other because they had a common language and they lived in the same time and place” (p.39).

Another definition from Lustig & Koester (2005) in their book, *Among Us*, explains, “Culture is a learned set of shared interpretations about beliefs, values, norms, and social practices that affects the behaviors of a relatively large group of people.

Thus culture is linked to human symbolic processes” (p.13).

Finally, a simpler definition comes from *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies* (2016), “Culture is an ongoing negotiation of learned patterns of beliefs, attitudes, values, and behaviors” (p.377).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy (2017) stress family, worldview, religion, history, values, social organizations and language as vital elements of culture. These elements of culture might help one better understand how intercultural communicators both share and differ in a variety of ways. “Worldview is the way a people interpret reality and events, including their images of themselves and how they relate to the world around them” (p.57). When one explores another’s culture, oftentimes one finds they are doing likewise.

This sense of definitional ambiguity has been discussed in the Open Education Resource (OER) *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies* (2016) as quoted below:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Culture is a complicated word to define, as there are at least six common ways that culture is used in the United States. For the purposes of exploring the communicative aspects of culture, we will define culture as the ongoing negotiation of learned and patterned beliefs, attitudes, values, and behaviors. When unpacking this definition, note that culture shouldn’t be conceptualized as stable and unchanging. Culture is “negotiated,” and...is dynamic....The definition also points out that culture is learned, which accounts for the importance of socializing institutions like family, school, peers, and the media. Culture is patterned in that there are recognizable widespread similarities among people within a cultural group. There is also deviation from and resistance to those patterns by individuals and subgroups within a culture, which is why cultural patterns change over time. Last, the definition acknowledges that culture influences our beliefs about what is true and false, our attitudes including our likes and dislikes, our values regarding what is right and wrong, and our behaviors. It is from these cultural influences that our Defining identities are formed (p.377).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Regardless of the definition used, individuals who have traveled to a new culture (or born witness to a newcomer to their area), especially outside their own language, know the simple frustrations of learning how to park the car correctly, use the correct currency, let alone ask for directions arise from cultural differences. To reduce frustrations, developing a variety of intercultural communication skills is helpful.

Defining Intercultural Communication:



Photo submitted by Lori Halverson-Wente,
used with permission

Having reviewed the definitions of culture and communication, looking more carefully at the defining characteristics of intercultural communication is essential to this Unit. Implicitly, if not explicitly, underpinning any definition of intercultural communication is one simple proposition—the requirement of a personal interaction with someone of a different culture, be that an intercultural interview or something else. If sharing and understanding meaning is our goal, our goal in intercultural communication is to do so in diverse settings with individuals who are from cultures different than our own. Hence, Lustig and Koester (2011) in their textbook, *Intercultural Competence*, briefly define intercultural communication as follows: “Intercultural communication occurs when large and important cultural differences create dissimilar interpretations and expectations about how to communicate competently” (p.52).

Intercultural communication happens in all contexts of communication: intrapersonal, interpersonal, small group/team, public, mass, mediated, etc. For a fuller treatment on Intercultural Communication, you can visit *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies* (2016) discussion on the topic: <http://open.lib.umn.edu/communication/chapter/8-3-intercultural-communication/>. This author shares:

It is through intercultural communication that we come to create, understand, and transform culture and identity. Intercultural communication is communication between people with differing cultural identities. One reason we should study intercultural communication is to foster greater self-awareness (Martin & Nakayama, 2010). Our thought process regarding culture is often ‘other focused,’ meaning that the culture of the other person or group is what stands out in our perception. However, the old adage ‘know thyself’ is appropriate, as we become more aware of our own culture by better understanding other cultures and perspectives. Intercultural communication can allow us to step outside of our comfortable, usual frame of reference and see our culture through a different lens. Additionally, as we become more self-aware, we may also become more ethical communicators as we challenge our ethnocentrism, or our tendency to view our own culture as superior to other cultures (Communication, 2016, p.404).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

When defining intercultural communication, it is important to remember these five thoughts as you complete your intercultural interview: “Engaging in intercultural communication is a complex activity. You need to be aware of (1) the uniqueness of each individual, (2) the hazards of over-generalizing, (3) the need to be objective, (4) the necessity for compromise, and (5) the myth of believing that communication is a cure-all” (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017, p.17). In doing so, the ultimate goal is to develop one’s intercultural communication competency and integrate this into their own life.

What is intercultural communication competence?



Rochester Diversity Council Photograph, used with permission

According to Darla Deardorff (2004), “Intercultural [communication] competence is the ability to interact effectively and appropriately in intercultural situations, based on specific attitudes, intercultural knowledge, skills and reflection” (p.5). A pyramid model represents how desired outcomes, both internal and external, are achieved by acquiring necessary preliminary competencies and skills. Deardorff’s model of intercultural communication competence, influential in its field, is explained (along with other similar models) at: <https://centerforinterculturaldialogue.files.wordpress.com/2010/07/intercultural-communication-competencies-study-material.pdf>).

A visual depiction of the model is shared at www.nafsa.org/_/file/_/theory_connections_intercultural_competence.pdf .

Undergirding Deardorff’s pyramid of intercultural communication competence and comprising its foundation are three characteristics allowing for its development and excellence: (1) motivation — developing cultural curiosity, general openness and respect for self/others; (2) knowledge — having a fund of knowledge to draw on to develop deep understanding, gaining knowledge of culture as well as specific cultural information and sociolinguistic awareness; (3) skills — possessing certain communication and listening skills such as listening, interpreting, analyzing, and evaluating (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017, p.217).

Specifically, as an exercise of intercultural communication competence, this unit adapts Deardorff (2004), Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy (2017) and others to: first, assist the student to thoughtfully prepare for the intercultural interview; second, gives the student a sense of how to effectively conduct the interview using perception checks, employing nonverbal and verbal skills, enhancing active listening and integrating compassionate listening when appropriate; and, third, help the student to prepare for the course’s essay assignment.

About the Unit's Assignment:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

The course unit assists the student in writing a brief essay assignment to demonstrate progress towards intercultural communication competence. To this end, the essay focuses upon personal reaction to, and acquired knowledge and analysis of, certain aspects of another culture relevant to effective intercultural communication leading to some measure of intercultural competence. The assignment asks the student the following: 1) learn about, and be aware of, one’s own culture and how it has shaped who and what one is so that honest and sound research of another culture to which she does not belong may occur; 2) interview someone from, or closely associated with, that culture and; 3) write a personal narrative analyzing the aforementioned process and the intercultural communication/interviewing experience arising from prior research, the process of the intercultural interview, and the connection made through the intercultural interview with a person of a different culture. A full assignment sheet, sample outlines and sample student essays are provided in the second section of this online resource.

Preparing for the Intercultural Interview:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

First and foremost, an intercultural interview should be conducted in a safe environment enabling both interviewer and interviewee to ask genuine, honest, and respectful questions with like tenored responses given. The interview, though, must be more than a loose exercise in stream-of-consciousness questioning. Hence, preparation for the interview is absolutely necessary as questions and prompts will need to have some connection or relevance to the student's essay. For example, the student will want to read corresponding chapters and sections from the primary textbook and other relevant resources, paying attention to cultural patterns and taxonomies/typologies as listed below one or more fitting to your essay and one or more with which you are comfortable along with concepts including, but not limited to, cultural identity, intercultural verbal and nonverbal communication, perception, and listening. Consider:

- Kohl's Analysis of American Cultural Patterns
 - interculturalcomm.wikispaces.com/Kohls%27+Guide+to+American+Values
- Hall's High-Low Context Cultural Taxonomy
 - online.seu.edu/high-and-low-context-cultures/
 - www.helsinki.fi/~tella/nishimuranevgitella299.pdf
 - http://www2.pacific.edu/sis/culture/pub/context_cultures_high_and_lo.htm
- Hofstede's Cultural Taxonomy
 - www.hofstede-insights.com/product/compare-countries/
- Kluckholm and Strodtbeck's Value Orientations
 - <https://scholarworks.gvsu.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1040&context=orpc>
- Project Globe which builds upon Hofstede and Kluckholm and Strodtbeck's work, Minkov's Cultural Dimension, etc.)
 - GlobeProject <http://globeproject.com/>
 - www.ccsenet.org/journal/index.php/ijbm/article/%20viewFile/10431/7448
 - https://www.tlu.ee/~sirvir/IKM/Leadership%20Dimensions/about_this_learning_object.html



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Sample questions for an interview, then, may include, in some fashion, the manner in which the interviewee experienced a collective vs. an individualistic family structure. Consider the variety of questions one could ask: Did you feel like a team or more as individuals in your family? Did your country stress what was "good for the country" or "what is good for the individual citizen?" Can you explain? How were decisions made in your family (e.g. where you'd go to college, who is responsible for what chores, etc.)?

Thinking about the questions to ask during the interview and considering the course content one would like to explore is helpful. At the same time, one will want to "just listen" without asking questions for some of the interview time. Chapter 6 focuses on how to use "active listening" as well as "compassionate listening skills" depending upon the context.

This page titled [1.1: Key Intercultural Communication Terms](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente \(Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project\)](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

1.2: Intercultural Communication and Cultural Relativism

Concerns about Cultural Relativism

The Tuckerian Turn:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

A simple, fruitful approach towards learning intercultural communication skills, as a parsimonious way of giving valuable perspective to the various skills and concepts demonstrating the relationship between communication, culture, perception, verbal and nonverbal language, listening, and intercultural communication/interviewing, is to apply the three questions Dr. Charles Tucker would pose to his students in every Communication class he taught at Northern Illinois University. Professor Tucker stated that: “Communication courses ask you to consider three fundamental questions: “Who am I?” “Who are you?” and, “What are we doing here together?” In a profound sense, these three questions enlighten and guide the approach to the class in this PressBook.



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Professor Tucker asks his students, “Who am I?” In doing so, Tucker’s first question points to an examination of one’s self and works towards the student “self” arriving at an understanding of both who the student is as a person and, necessarily, having knowledge of one’s own culture—after all, the elements or components of their own culture help define who the student is—who the student regards herself to be, and how, through what kind of lens, the student perceives the world. If we hope to move on towards intercultural communication competence, necessary for navigating our globalized world, individuals must honestly confront and answer, but then move beyond the first question and be open to taking the risk of asking those of other cultures the second question, “Who are you?”



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

The first question, “Who am I?” is a key to opening the door that allows relationship and knowledge between the “self” and the “other.” Now, as explained above, this open relationship and knowledge are gained by asking the second question, “Who are you?” Through this question, posed to someone (the other) of another very different culture, real intercultural communication begins to emerge. Remember that, before asking questions of someone of another culture, one’s own culture is vital in shaping your individual identity, values, worldview, beliefs, biases, language, religion, and means and methods of interpersonal communication. Having gained some knowledge of oneself and one’s culture along with the interrelationship between the two, the basis for meaningful intercultural communication with the other is more solid and success more likely. This stands to reason, as possessing knowledge of the other’s culture, i.e., a knowledge of the same cultural concepts, some mentioned above, that are used to

understand one's own culture can now be focused on the culture of the other. Such knowledge allows for better, more informed, questioning and dialogue by allowing the student to ask relevant and useful questions directed to genuine learning about the other and their culture.

Cultural Relativism: The Elephant in the Discourse



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

A note of caution must be made, however. As just mentioned, the student, to be an effective cultural communicator/interviewer, needs to be keenly aware of their own predispositions and assumptions and that, put broadly, that their own cultural forms who or what they are. Given this, as Stephen Fuchs (2001) points out, “cultural observers are also cultured observers, they come with a ‘habitus,’ which means that observers are [conditioned by their own culture and] are trained and accustomed to using distinctions of their own culture...[which] provides observers with the material and symbolic means of observation....” (p.155).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Fuchs (2001) argues for the pervasiveness of culture in shaping vital aspects of its members' identity. Still, the profound and pervasive influence of one's own culture in shaping perception and worldview and imparting to its members its own peculiar categories, distinctions, and means of approaching and learning from the world and from other cultures does not, in and of itself, prevent the possibility of acquiring a genuine, meaningful, and, in a real sense, objective, understanding of other cultures through careful, informed, and respectful intercultural communication/interviewing. Intercultural communication competence of great meaning and depth may be arrived at precisely because, though such communication indeed occurs between individuals shaped by their own unique and profoundly distinct cultures, the even more profound similarity of a common humanity or human nature visible and accessible via intercultural communication trumps the barriers of cultural differences. In fact, the existence of a common human nature is the key that allows the interviewer and interviewee to open closed doors and begin to acquire a deeper understanding of own each of their cultures. This reservation against cultural relativism, specifically linguistic relativism stems from the “Sapir-Whorf hypothesis.” Hussein (2012) explains that the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis asserts the influence of language on thought and perception, which strongly implies that speakers of different languages from different cultures perceive reality differently—language, in effect, determines worldview (p.642).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

At this juncture, it is important to deeply stress once more that human beings are not necessarily bound and blinded by culture with its unique categories, concepts, and constructs when honestly, respectfully, and openly observing, learning about and understanding other cultures. That this mutual understanding may occur is, unfortunately, contested or clouded by the pervasive underlying

concept of “cultural relativism.” Many scholars and students hold, consciously or unconsciously, some form of cultural relativism which regards cultural, religious, social, legal, familial, economic, etc. beliefs, practices, and traditions as relative to a given culture (Chin-Dahler, 2010). It is premised on the idea that all aspects of human cultures are relative to one another; that is, all cultures are equally valid and any standard of evaluation, assessment and judgment must be culturally internal only—any cultural criticism must come from persons of that culture. Persons of other cultures and traditions characterized by differing perceptions, values, and worldviews cannot hope to reach the point where any moral judgment or evaluation regarding the other culture can be reasonably made apart from cultural biases—such evaluations are labeled “**ethnocentric**” (a strong tendency to reflexively view one’s own cultural worldview, beliefs, and practices as superior to those of other cultures); and is considered a legitimate obstacle to intercultural understanding, respect and dignity. **Cultural relativism** holds that a culture’s values emerge in the context of particular social, cultural, economic, political, geographical and environmental conditions. Hence, each culture is relative to one another and can only be assessed according to its own lens, boundaries, and worldview.



Photo by: Kim Sin on the RCTC Service Trip

In this view, to be culturally sensitive and amenable to communicating with, and learning about, other cultures, one must adopt an attitude of openness, neutrality and closely monitor or even censor one’s judgments that, as indicated, stem from one’s own unique cultural worldview and biases. Because, for cultural relativism, every person’s values and worldview are culturally determined, no reasonable normative judgments can be made—all cultures and aspects of cultures are equal before the bar of values and morality which are, in and of themselves, culturally determined and hence relative. Thus, we must be tolerant and open-minded in the relativistic sense by wholly suspending judgment when learning about or interacting with those of other cultures. So, for example, a westerner has no basis upon which to legitimately criticize the cultural practice of female genital mutilation. In France, immigrants and refugees who practice female genital mutilation, polygamy, arranged marriages of underage girls or coerced marriages of women, often openly defend their cultural practices as legitimate simply because they are cultural practices they wish to preserve of which a westerner, or western values, according to cultural relativism, hold no truck. In Guatemala, a stunted child of 4 years old wanders aimlessly in the dark, utterly ignored by global sophisticates of other cultures who, as cultural relativists and global citizens, ignore the child because of the Guatemalan practice of poor women and their children coming down from the mountains to beg from tourists for a living—who dares judge, act rightly?



Photo from Kim Sin from the RCTC Cambodia Service Trip

For cultural relativism, all outsiders must, in the worst sense of the word, be tolerant and non-judgmental in the face of cultural practices and beliefs other than one’s own. Such a stance is unfortunate. In the history of the United States, many critics foreign and domestic, appealing to standards of universal human justice as articulated in the Declaration of Independence (for Lincoln, our founding document), openly and rightly criticized our institution of slavery as abhorrent not only to universal human rights and equality, but stood as a glaring example of hypocrisy in the face of our own culture’s guiding principles of human equality and unalienable rights, true everywhere and always.



Photo by: Kim Sin on the RCTC Service Trip

Cultural practices from which most Westerners instinctively shrink, such as cannibalism, human sacrifice, and female genital mutilation, and human trafficking have had to be accorded their own integrity, lest the culture that produced them be demeaned or viewed critically and in an ethnocentric light. Other issues begin to “blur.” The world weighed in on whether or not children should be separated from their parents at the US Border as the parents sought asylum. The continued conversation about children’s rights concerning work, education, and access to clean water and sanitation show these rights are not universally held throughout the world. Yet, if one believes in human rights, does not one believe in a sense of some truth?

Professor Patrick Deenan (2012), referring to American culture, was struck by Allan Bloom’s critique of relativism.

Bloom made an altogether different argument: American youth were increasingly raised to believe that nothing was True, that every belief was merely the expression of an opinion or preference. Americans were raised to be ‘cultural relativists,’ with a default attitude of non-judgmentalism. Not only all other traditions but even one’s own (whatever that might be) were simply views that happened to be held by some people and could not be judged as inferior or superior to any other. [No opinion held by one person can be determined to be superior to the opinion of another; nor can any one culture be assessed by the values of another or universal values, for that matter]. He bemoaned particularly the decline of household and community religious upbringing in which the worldviews of children were shaped by a comprehensive vision of the good and the true. In one arresting passage, he waxed nostalgic for the days when people cared: ‘It was not necessarily the best of times in America when Catholic and Protestants were suspicious of and hated one another, but at least they were taking their beliefs seriously’ ... (Deneen, 2012).

Of course, if values, beliefs, attitudes, language, worldviews, etc. were, in fact, fundamentally culture-bound as cultural relativism contends, then it follows that researchers/business people/individuals from one culture could never hope to understand and communicate deeply and meaningfully with those of another culture. Ironically, the simple fact that the very concepts of culture, intercultural communication, and intercultural communication competence are all “constructs” or insights of various Western thinkers of Western cultures does not, by dint of origin, necessarily diminish their explanatory effectiveness or usefulness for the mutual cultural communication competency and understanding between individuals of different cultures (Nisbett, 2003).

The Tuckerian Turn: Beware the “Echo Chamber:”



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Interviewees who attempt to forthrightly respond to the “Who are you?” question(s) impart valuable insights into their particular perspective of their own culture. These insights emerge from Professor Tucker’s third question, “What are we doing here together?” As we shall see, it is this question that eventually leads to intercultural communication competence and/or confidence.

Regarding Professor Tucker’s third question, “What are we doing here together?” along with its intercultural perspective, it must be mentioned, unfortunately, that in these divisive times there often exists a barrier or wall, largely self-imposed, which impedes or prohibits moving from the notion of “Who am I?” (i.e., understanding our own culture) to an honest consideration of the next question, “Who are you?”—a question asked of someone from a different culture that is fundamental to begin the process of learning about other cultures and thus ultimately engaging competently in intercultural communication through Tucker’s third question. A wall is built between cultures; it prevents moving forward from Professor Tucker’s first question by limiting, in our social media age, our communication to those people who are “just like me” in many aspects of culture: nation, appearance, political opinions,

economic circumstances, religious beliefs, social practices and overall values, norms, and worldview. A straightjacket is applied and tied to our opinions and conversations, limiting our conversation to unchallenging “like-minded friends” and comfortable “contacts”—often termed the echo chamber—in which the conversation consists of “Who am I?” and perhaps “Who are we?” and, finally, “Why are they out to get us—we who are guardians of the true and good?”



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

In his professional blog, seminal Communication scholar John Stewart (2017) remarks,

It's called the '**echo chamber** syndrome....' We only listen or speak inside closed chambers that echo [and amplify] our current beliefs and opinions."

The result, Stewart continues, is polarized (or polarizing) communication of one-sided arguments, spoken to the choir, that necessarily “reduce[s] the quality of our critical thinking” (2017). Moreover, says Stewart, such communication divides us from friends, family and colleagues—truly a danger to a democracy the health of which requires open, honest civil discourse. In sum, we become trapped in a “Thunderdome” of our own making, where any deviation from the loudest “Echo” is promptly ostracized. Read more: <http://www.johnstewart.org/blog/2017/12/8/echo-chamber-or-community.html>. To gain more information about critical thinking, in general, and to gain a better vocabulary on terms related to critical inquiry see: <http://www.criticalthinking.org/pages/open-minded-inquiry/579>.

Note that cultural relativism is entirely consistent with this development. If no means exists to assess and evaluate opinions, they are all equal after all. Certainly, then, the loudest opinions shouting down rival opinions as “fake news” will prevail.

This page titled [1.2: Intercultural Communication and Cultural Relativism](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente](#) ([Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project](#)) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

1.3: Perception

Perception and Perception-Checking

How shall I talk of the sea to the frog, if he has never left the pond? How shall I talk of the frost to the bird of the summer land if he has never left the place of his birth? And how shall I talk of life with the sage if he is a prisoner of his doctrine? ~ Chung Tzu

Overview



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

This section examines, first, the important concept of perception, explaining the three steps involved in creating a perception: selection, organization, and interpretation.

Second, this section explores how the communication skill of a “perception check” can assist one in an intercultural environment.

What is Perception

In Intercultural Communication, perception itself, along with the associated skills of perception-checking (often stressed in interpersonal communication), are necessary for the process of intercultural communication to begin. **Perception** is more of a process whereby each of us creates “mental images” of the world that surrounds us, that is, of the “world out there” (Green, Fairchild, Knudsen, & Lease-Gubrud, 2018).

Moreover Green, Fairchild, Knudsen, & Lease-Gubrud (2018) explain:

Perceptions determine communication choices, so understanding this process helps us to avoid common perceptual problems. We gain greater insight into how there can be multiple, equally valid perceptions of the same stimuli, increasing our ability to respect a range of diverse views. A significant implication of this understanding is it reveals how much responsibility we receiver-based communicators have in the success or failure of an event. We have to be responsible for those perceptions (Module II, Section 1).



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

The importance of perception as a concept is evidenced by the nature of communication simply. Communication, recalling Professor Tucker’s three questions (Who am I? Who are you? and What are we doing here together?), may be understood as an intentional relationship between the Self and the Other. Fundamentally, then, the perception one’s Self possesses of the Other, and, vice-versa, informs the nature and character of the communication which establishes, forms, and furthers (or, unfortunately, perhaps may fail to do so) the relationship between the two.

Perception and Barriers to Communication



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Individual perceptions and intercultural communication are decisively shaped by culture, that is, they are formed by culturally ingrained and instilled attitudes, beliefs, values, media, worldview, and language (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017).

Given certain profound and oftentimes strange differences characterizing various cultures, a heightened sensitivity or apprehension on the part of one or both of the intercultural interlocutors can arise and pose some difficulties. A heightened, uniformed sensitivity or feeling of intense communication apprehension may pose a significant barrier to accurately understanding one another and is a threat to beginning and/or continuing the process towards obtaining intercultural communication/interviewing competence (Communication, 2016).



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

There are a number of reasons for intercultural communication apprehension (Cavanaugh, 2015). First, remember that some degree of communication apprehension is quite natural, especially if neither person trying to engage has any substantial knowledge of the other's culture. If apprehension is not addressed at this beginning stage, intercultural communication incompetence is quite likely to occur. Second, some individuals are, by nature, less comfortable and have difficulty engaging in communication with others of their own culture much less those of other very different cultures (Communication, 2016). Introverts often approach a Self-Other situation, intercultural or otherwise, with a need to process their feelings and thoughts so as to be prepared before moving into any intercultural conversation or experience. Extroverts, on the other hand, may very well have moved on or prematurely jumped in before thinking through the complexities of the situation. As always, the middle ground of an equal measure of thought and action is helpful. Third, for many, especially those who have grown up without any contact or experience with people of a different culture, initial encounters with people of different cultures may be anxiety-producing. Such persons may be caught up in culturally ingrained and misguided perceptions of unknown cultures (Cavanaugh, 2015). It is important, then, as Green, Fairchild, Knudsen, & Lease-Gubrud (2018) point out, that there is a responsibility involved: to "...gain greater insight into how there can be multiple, equally valid perceptions of the same stimuli, increasing our ability to respect a range of diverse views" (Module 2, Section 2). Finally, in the interview process itself, some students worry about sounding like a "therapist" or "salesperson." Gudykunst and Kim (1995) provide insight which was aptly summarized by Glaser (n.d.):



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

The increased uncertainty in interactions with strangers is accompanied by higher levels of anxiety, as we anticipate a wider array of possible negative outcomes. We may worry about damage to our self-esteem from feeling confused and out of control. We may

fear the possibility of being incompetent, or being exploited. We may worry about being perceived negatively by the stranger. And we may worry that interacting with a stranger will bring disapproval from members of our own group. Generally these anxieties can be reduced by paying more conscious attention to the communication process, and by gathering more information on the stranger. The authors add a further caution. Generally, individuals tend to explain their own behavior by reference to the situation. Observers tend to attribute an individual's behavior to elements of that individual's character. When interacting with strangers we are especially likely to attribute their behavior to their character, and then to view their character as typical of their culture (or race, etc.). That is, we are especially likely to interpret a stranger's behavior in light of our stereotypes about what 'those kind of people' are like (Glaser, n.d.).

Overcoming Perceptual Barriers



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

The concepts of perception and perception checking, then, are skills that help to avoid such perspectives. The key to accurate perception and perception checking is possessing an informed cultural sensitivity. According to McCrosky (2001), sources of communication, and, indeed, intercultural communication anxiety are related to trait, context, audience and situation. Thus, in the process of communicating, taking time to acquire and exercise one's perception-checking skills with one's intercultural dialogic interlocutor (and vice versa) is essential. However, an informed cultural sensitivity is necessary for the interviewer in communicating with the interviewee. This sensitivity succinctly conveys respect, honest curiosity, and a desire to learn from and hear the story of the Other—this is something akin to, “compassionate listening” (sometimes also referred to as “deep listening”), which will be explored later. Practically, it also has the effect of lessening communication apprehension thus allowing for richer, deeper conversation.

Selection, Organization, and Interpretation

Perception itself is further defined by Neuliep (2018) as the “mental interpretation of external stimuli via sensation” (the accumulating of external stimuli through visual, auditory, olfactory, taste, and tactile senses). That is, the first stage of perception must be the **selection** of sense data or the “raw information,” perceived and taken in by the senses (p.157). As Mclean (2018) explains:



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

...[W]hat we perceive is culturally bound. We are taught from a very young age what to pay attention to and what to ignore. We learn what is important in our culture and look for those clues to make meaning. We often ignore clues that we've learned are considered unimportant. Sometimes we miss valuable clues that are right under our noses. Learning to recognize that we perceive stimuli in different ways helps us start to address this central question: Why don't we all see things the same way? Understanding ourselves is fundamental to understanding others and intercultural communication (Section 2.2).

Now, as Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy (2017) point out, we humans live in “an information-saturated world [or culture]”—constantly inundated by physical and psychological factors, that, due to sheer number, we are not able to select and process. Scholars in the Intercultural Communication field, then, usually posit some steps, perceptual filters, often consisting of a **three-step**

process–selection, organization, and interpretation–to help order stimuli (Jandt, 2013). Keep in mind, during the first step of selection, the individual communicator chooses, consciously or unconsciously, which of the stimuli to pay attention to and which to ignore. With the second step, that stimuli chosen must be **organized**, after which, in the third step, **interpretation**, meaning is assigned to perceived sense data (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017).

Selection



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies (2016) expands upon how selection works:

We tend to pay attention to information that is salient. Salience is the degree to which something attracts our attention in a particular context. The thing attracting our attention can be abstract, like a concept, or concrete, like an object. For example, a person's identity as a Native American may become salient when they are protesting at the Columbus Day parade in Denver, Colorado. Or a bright flashlight shining in your face while camping at night is sure to be salient. The degree of salience depends on three features (Fiske & Taylor, 1991). We tend to find salient things that are visually or aurally stimulating and things that meet our needs or interests. Lastly, expectations affect what we find salient" (p.55).

Organization

Again, drawing from the Open Education Resource (OER), *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies* (2016), the second step of perception, organization, is also complex:



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Organizing is the second part of the perception process, in which we sort and categorize information that we perceive based on innate and learned cognitive patterns. Three ways we sort things into patterns are by using proximity, similarity, and difference (Coren, 1980). In terms of proximity, we tend to think that things that are close together go together. For example, have you ever been waiting to be helped in a business and the clerk assumes that you and the person standing beside you are together? The slightly awkward moment usually ends when you and the other person in line look at each other, then back at the clerk, and one of you explains that you are not together. Even though you may have never met that other person in your life, the clerk used a basic perceptual organizing cue to group you together because you were standing in proximity to one another. Since we organize perceptual information based on proximity, a person may perceive that two people are together, just because they are standing close together in line.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

We also organize information that we take in based on **difference**. In this case, we assume that the item that looks or acts different from the rest doesn't belong with the group. Perceptual errors involving people and assumptions of difference can be especially awkward, if not offensive. My friend's mother, who is Vietnamese American, was attending a conference at which another attendee assumed she was a hotel worker and asked her to throw something away for her. In this case, my friend's mother was a person of color at a convention with mostly white attendees, so an impression was formed based on the other person's perception of this difference.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

These strategies for organizing information are so common that they are built into how we teach our children basic skills and how we function in our daily lives. I'm sure we all had to look at pictures in grade school and determine which things went together and which thing didn't belong. If you think of the literal act of organizing something, like your desk at home or work, we follow these same strategies. If you have a bunch of papers and mail on the top of your desk, you will likely sort papers into separate piles for separate classes or put bills in a separate place than personal mail. You may have one drawer for pens, pencils, and other supplies and another drawer for files. In this case you are grouping items based on similarities and differences. You may also group things based on proximity, for example, by putting financial items like your checkbook, a calculator, and your pay stubs in one area so you can update your budget efficiently. In summary, we simplify information and look for patterns to help us more efficiently communicate and get through life.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

We also group things together based on **similarity**. We tend to think similar-looking or similar-acting things belong together. I have two friends that I occasionally go out with, and we are all three males, around the same age, of the same race, with short hair and glasses. Aside from that, we don't really look alike, but on more than one occasion a server at a restaurant has assumed that we're brothers. Despite the fact that many of our other features are different, the salient features are organized based on similarity and the three of us are suddenly related. We also organize information that we take in based on difference. In this case, we assume that the item that looks or acts different from the rest doesn't belong with the group.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Simplification and categorizing based on patterns isn't necessarily a bad thing. In fact, without this capability we would likely not have the ability to speak, read, or engage in other complex cognitive/behavioral functions. Our brain innately categorizes and files information and experiences away for later retrieval, and different parts of the brain are responsible for different sensory experiences. In short, it is natural for things to group together in some ways. There are differences among people, and looking for patterns helps us in many practical ways. However, the judgments we place on various patterns and categories are not natural; they are learned and culturally and contextually relative. Our perceptual patterns do become unproductive and even unethical when the judgments we associate with certain patterns are based on stereotypical or prejudicial thinking. We also organize interactions and interpersonal experiences based on our firsthand experiences. When two people experience the same encounter differently, misunderstandings and conflict may result. Punctuation refers to the structuring of information into a timeline to determine the cause (stimulus) and effect (response) of our communication interactions (Sillars, 1980). Applying this concept to interpersonal conflict can help us see how the perception process extends beyond the individual to the interpersonal level. This concept also helps illustrate how organization and interpretation can happen together and how interpretation can influence how we organize information and vice versa (Communication, 2017, pp.58-59).

Interpretation

The free "OER" online textbook, *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies* (2016), explains more about the interpretation step:



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Although selecting and organizing incoming stimuli happens very quickly, and sometimes without much conscious thought, interpretation can be a much more deliberate and conscious step in the perception process. Interpretation is the third part of the perception process, in which we assign meaning to our experiences using mental structures known as schemata. Schemata are like databases of stored, related information that we use to interpret new experiences. We all have fairly complicated schemata that have developed over time as small units of information combine to make more meaningful complexes of information.

...It's important to be aware of schemata because our interpretations affect our behavior. For example, if you are doing a group project for class and you perceive a group member to be shy based on your schema of how shy people communicate, you may avoid giving him presentation responsibilities in your group project because you do not think shy people make good public speakers. Schemata also guide our interactions, providing a script for our behaviors. We know, in general, how to act and communicate in a waiting room, in a classroom, on a first date, and on a game show. Even a person who has never been on a game show can develop a schema for how to act in that environment by watching *The Price Is Right*, for example. People go to great lengths to make shirts with clever sayings or act enthusiastically in hopes of being picked to be a part of the studio audience and hopefully become a contestant on the show.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

As we have seen, schemata are used to interpret others' behavior and form impressions about who they are as a person. To help this process along, we often solicit information from people to help us place them into a pre-existing schema. In the United States and many other Western cultures, people's identities are often closely tied to what they do for a living. When we introduce others, or ourselves, occupation is usually one of the first things we mention. Think about how your communication with someone might differ if he or she were introduced to you as an artist versus a doctor. We make similar interpretations based on where people are from, their age, their race, and other social and cultural factors. We will learn more about how culture, gender, and other factors influence our perceptions as we continue through the chapter. In summary, we have schemata about individuals, groups, places, and things, and these schemata filter our perceptions before, during, and after interactions. As schemata are retrieved from memory, they are executed, like computer programs or apps on your smartphone, to help us interpret the world around us. Just like computer programs and apps must be regularly updated to improve their functioning, competent communicators update and adapt their schemata as they have new experiences (Communication, 2016, pp.61-62).

Summary of the Steps of Perception



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Selecting, organizing and interpreting, then, all have unique roles in formulating the overall perception one has of a person, place or thing. McLean (2018) stresses the intercultural elements involved in perception:

Our perception process is largely universal, even when we consider the range of sight, hearing, feeling, smell, or taste. What differs is how we perceive it, and our interpretations reflect our cultural backgrounds. We can easily recognize, for example, that some people can discern all the flavor "notes" in a wine, while to others all red wines taste almost the same. We can also acknowledge that we change over time, and young eyes often work better than older eyes. That said, it is not as much about whether our eyes are young or have seen many seasons as what we focus on or ignore during that perception process that makes a significant difference. Indeed, what it means to be "young" or "old" varies by culture. We perceive through our senses of touch, taste, smell, sight, and sound, and we form perceptions through the lens of our cultural background (Section 2.2).

This, then, gives rise to the need to check if our perceptions are correct. Perception checking is a skill used to do just that.

Perception Checking



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

As humans, we often assume that we are aware of, and even understand, what other people are thinking and feeling — of that our own perceptions of others are correct and updated. In truth, though, we usually do not take the time to clearly attempt to ascertain in a nonjudgmental and clarifying way through perception checking questions: “You seem upset;” “Are you?;” or “I get the impression that this exchange has hurt your feelings in some way. Is this true?” (Brookfield & Preskill, 2005). Gudykunst & Kim (1995) points out that one of the ways to reduce ambiguity and facilitate the process of intercultural communication is through frequent perception checking. Simply put, through perception checking, we describe what we perceive the other person to be thinking or feeling and then request clearly and in a non-threatening manner that the other person confirms or corrects our perception. According to Brookfield and Preskill (2005), perception checks send the valuable message to one’s interlocutor of another culture that you truly want to listen, observe, and then understand their communication, verbal or nonverbal. As we shall see, there is a necessary tie between perception checking and compassionate listening.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Compassionate listening is most simply defined as a “quality of listening which creates a safe container for people to be free to express themselves and to go to the level of their deep concerns....[It means] listening deeply to the needs and suffering of others and respecting their rights to their opinions...[forming the] basis of...successful dialogue, [which] can only take place when people are really ready to listen to each other and to themselves” (Hwoschinsky, 2006, p.3). To adequately practice the dynamic process of compassionate listening, then, perception checks, Brookfield and Preskill (2005) accentuate, are especially important in intercultural communication encounters. Given that individuals from different cultures sense, interpret, and understand the world in different ways, perception checks can help ameliorate the inherent ambiguity that is part of intercultural communication (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017).



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

In the process of successful intercultural communication, one need not overly worry about perception checks interrupting the flow of conversation and thus create a burden or barrier to effective communication. It is just the opposite, and, in fact, should take precedence over the discussion. Why? If a perception check occurs, for example: “I heard you mention the term ‘class’ several

times as you described your upbringing. I am wondering, are you saying that racism always has an underlying economic cause or is it primarily a finite issue? Can you explain that a bit more?” Another, less “technically structured” example of a simple perception checking question is: “Did I paraphrase your last comment correctly?” Note, the discussion itself stops so that the person of the other culture may think about and answer the given perception check. Conversation is allowed to check and clarify what was previously said and then confirm the perception check. Only after both interlocutors involved in the conversation have checked their perceptions and made clear their meanings so as they are satisfied with the meaning and nuance of the conversation can the discussion continue (Brookfield and Preskill, 2005).

Brookfield and Preskill (2005) remind us to consider that though the natural flow of the conversation was interrupted, it was necessary to clarify the accuracy of the communication and enhance a mutual common understanding lest the meaning and message of the conversation be lost or diminished and cause unneeded discomfort or even halt the conversation.



Ren Olive submitted photo used with permission from the photographer

Perception-checking is vital to making sure that all involved are interpreting the meaning and message fully and accurately. Importantly, this process gives those whose voice is habitually misunderstood and are victims of miscommunication, for a number of reasons, e.g., a persecuted minority or practitioner of an alternative lifestyle incongruent with the dominant culture, etc., an opportunity to put forth or communicate honestly and accurately the message or part of their life-narrative that they may desperately want to communicate. Such a process, then, allows those persecuted and misunderstood to express their narrative or story in a dignified, humane fashion, thus giving them an opportunity to express their felt human experience. When creating a perception check, you will use three steps, as quoted below from the free open education resource textbook, *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies* (2016):

Step 1: Describe the behavior or situation without evaluating or judging it.

Step 2: Think of some possible interpretations of the behavior, being aware of attributions and other influences on the perception process.

Step 3: Verify what happened and ask for clarification from the other person’s perspective. Be aware of punctuation, since the other person likely experienced the event differently than you” (p.110).

Perception Format



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

During a perception check, the standard format is as follows:

Step 1: Perception checks include “I” language and a clearly stated observation or fact: “I heard you mention ____.

Step 2: This is followed by 2 possible interpretations: I am wondering if ____ or ____ is the case for you?

Step 3: Finally, the perception check is completed with a clarification request: Can you clarify?"

This page titled [1.3: Perception](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente](#) (Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

1.4: Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal Communication, More than “Body Language”

Chapter Overview:



Rochester Diversity Council photo, used with permission

Often called, “body language,” **nonverbal communication** is much more and is essential to consider in intercultural settings. It involves everything that is not in a grammatical structure (so non-words). “Nonverbal communication is a process of generating meaning using behavior other than words. Rather than thinking of nonverbal communication as the opposite of or as separate from verbal communication, it’s more accurate to view them as operating side by side—as part of the same system” (Communication, 2016, p.165).

Nonverbal Communication Defined:

Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy (2017) further define nonverbal communication:

...[N]onverbal communication involves all those nonverbal stimuli in a communication setting that are generated by both the source and his or her use of the environment and that have potential message value for the source and/or receiver. It is not by chance that our definition is somewhat lengthy. We wanted to offer a definition that would not only establish the boundaries of nonverbal communication but also reflect how the process actually functions. Part of that functioning involves (1) intentional and unintentional messages and (2) the reciprocal relationship between verbal and nonverbal messages (p.297).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Students in an intercultural communication class frequently hope to gain a checklist of what to do or not do when in a new country. As there are more countries to write about than there is time in a semester, that goal often must be narrowed. The intercultural communication interview assignment helps students to narrow focus upon cultures they are most interested by making such a “checklist.” Think about how one mindfully adorns oneself— jewelry, book bags, even cars. These messages are often intentional, but the effect, such as wearing a jacket to an event that has a logo or image on it that might be offensive to others, could be unintentional but perceived as intentional. Even one’s body might “unknowingly” or “unintentionally” communicate (e.g., generalizations are made about individuals who are obese or very thin). The encoding and decoding of nonverbal communication are complex processes and show the power of nonverbal communication to impact the perception process.

The free, Open Education Resource, *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies* (2016) explains how nonverbal communication and personal identities are related:



creative commons photo from
burst.shopify.com

Nonverbal communication expresses who we are. Our identities (the groups to which we belong, our cultures, our hobbies and interests, etc.) are conveyed nonverbally through the way we set up our living and working spaces, the clothes we wear, the way we carry ourselves, and the accents and tones of our voices. Our physical bodies give others impressions about who we are, and some of these features are more under our control than others. Height, for example, has been shown to influence how people are treated and perceived in various contexts. Our level of attractiveness also influences our identities and how people perceive us.

Although we can temporarily alter our height or looks—for example, with different shoes or different color contact lenses—we can only permanently alter these features using more invasive and costly measures such as cosmetic surgery. We have more control over some other aspects of nonverbal communication in terms of how we communicate our identities. For example, the way we carry and present ourselves through posture, eye contact, and tone of voice can be altered to present ourselves as warm or distant depending on the context (pp.174-175).

Today, though, one might physically alter one's body to better match their identity. For example, transgender individuals have more legal and medical options, although not all medical insurance policies, clinic locations, or states honor the rights to do so. In fact, some college students who identify as transgender have reported problems filling out forms for college dormitories, financial aid, and even when seeking medical assistance (Seelman, 2016).



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Aside from our physical body, artifacts, which are the objects and possessions that surround us, also communicate our identities. Examples of artifacts include our clothes, jewelry, and space decorations. In all the previous examples, implicit norms or explicit rules can affect how we nonverbally present ourselves. For example, in a particular workplace it may be a norm (implicit) for people in management positions to dress casually, or it may be a rule (explicit) that different levels of employees wear different uniforms or follow particular dress codes. We can also use nonverbal communication to express identity characteristics that do not match up with who we actually think we are. Through changes to nonverbal signals, a capable person can try to appear helpless, a guilty person can try to appear innocent, or an uninformed person can try to appear credible (Communication, 2016, pp.174-175).

Tips for Nonverbal Communication:

Nonverbal and verbal communication are intertwined. Realizing one's movements, posture, eye contact, and even weight, height and eye color can impact an intercultural communication interaction is the first step toward gaining competency in this area. The steps toward integrating new intercultural sensitive behaviors into one's toolbox of communication skills can often follow the persuasive model: awareness, understanding, agreement, action, then integration (Osborn, et. al). To be aware is a strong step forward. Researching and interacting with individuals from new co-cultures and cultures prior to the intercultural communication interview will give one a set of questions to ask the interviewee about.

Psychology Today contributor, Dr. Marianna Pogosyan (2017), an intercultural consultant, offers three easy tips to consider when communicating with someone from another culture and/or nation:



Not all cultures embrace the “selfie.” Ask before taking a photo. creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

1. *Try to be pleasant.* Most people like pleasant people and a simple smile goes a long way.
2. *Be interested.* Show interest in other people, languages and cultural artifacts. Ask questions. Then intercultural interaction doesn’t become a hassle – it becomes an adventure.
3. *Try to learn something important about the language and culture of your interlocutor.* For example, learn and try some simple phrases. “Good morning,” “please,” and “thank you” go a long way to greasing many interactions. A lot of people will then feel like they want to help you out, which can help you get over any kind of communication issues. And, you’ll grow as you interact (Pogosyan, 2017).

Links to Culture Specific Nonverbal Communication Do’s & Don’ts

- General Advice: <https://www.andrews.edu/~tidwell/bsad560/NonVerbal.html>
- Japanese Culture: <https://web.uri.edu/iaics/files/11-Cecilia-B-Ikeguchi.pdf>

This page titled [1.4: Nonverbal Communication](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente](#) and [Mark Halverson-Wente](#) (Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

1.5: Verbal Communication

Verbal Communication – Sticks and Stones...

Chapter Overview:



creative commons photo from
burst.shopify.com

Better understanding how verbal symbols create meaning will help during the intercultural communication interview. However, there is no magic word one can use to reduce uncertainty and create a similar meaning. This chapter clarifies how language can help create a sense of connection as well as provide a barrier.

Verbal Communication Defined:

Verbal communication refers to words. Words are a type of **symbol**. The free, Open Education Resource, *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies* (2016) explains:



Halverson-Wente photo, used with permission

Our language system is primarily made up of symbols. A symbol is something that stands in for or represents something else. Symbols can be communicated verbally (speaking the word hello), in writing (putting the letters H-E-L-L-O together), or nonverbally (waving your hand back and forth). In any case, the symbols we use stand in for something else, like a physical object or an idea; they do not actually correspond to the thing being referenced in any direct way (pp.113-114).

As noted above, “verbal communication” is our language use. In intercultural communication, there may exist either entirely different language use, a person using a second language, or even, both individuals communicating in a common second language.



Photo Submitted by Jordan Wente, used with permission

Speaking in a different language gives one a new outlook. Jordan, a Rochester Community and Technical College Alum, pursued his master’s degree in Denmark. Generally, the international university he attended used English as the common currency of language. However, as one of his college majors was Spanish, he soon found himself drawn to speaking Spanish with his classmates from Spanish-speaking countries and a special bond was made.

Language defines. The defining ability of language relates to intercultural communication and barriers, such as stigma, that language can impose. Galinsky, A. D., Hugenberg, K., Groom, C., & Bodenhausen, G. (2003) explain the power of stigma:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Stigma, according to Goffman, is an attribute that discredits and reduces the person ‘from a whole and usual person to a tainted, discounted one’ (Goffman, 1963, p.3). Social stigma links a negatively valued attribute to a social identity or group membership. Stigma is said to exist when individuals ‘possess (or are believed to possess) some attribute, or characteristic, that conveys a social identity that is devalued in a particular social context’ (Crocker, Major & Steele, 1998, p.505). Given these criteria, there are myriad groups in our own culture that tend to be The Reappropriation of Stigmatizing Labels considered stigmatized. Ethnic minorities, such as African Americans or Native Americans, persons with physical or mental disabilities, gay men and lesbians, and the obese can all be considered stigmatized groups. To be stigmatized often means to be economically disadvantaged, to be the target of negative stereotypes, and to be rejected interpersonally (Crocker, Voelkl, Testa & Major, 1998). Name calling (Smythe & Seidman, 1957) may be a favorite strategy for calling forth these harmful sequelae of stigma (pp.224-225).



Halverson-Wente submitted photo,
used with permission

While stigmatizing language generally comes from persons in positions of “privilege” to define others in some way (remember social capital can equal privilege too), systematic policy, language structure, and attitudes can also create damaging language. Think of individuals with disabilities being called “crippled” or how often one hears, “Oh, that is *handicapped* parking.” Remember the person first – the “person with a disability” is not a “disabled person” simply. The order of the words can demonstrate an emphasis upon the person. Another example is the stigma surrounding how individuals with a mental health diagnosis are called: crazy, insane, mentally ill, nuts, loco, etc. Moving past the stigmatized “other” and into a healthy image means re-evaluating the language used to name, define, detain, diagnosis, and otherwise label others. We live in an era where preferred pronouns or other inclusive language choices are often quickly dismissed as politically correct and careless. Moreover, “Can’t you take a joke?” statements come from our own leaders after making racist, sexist, homophobic, xenophobic or other offensive phases. Making a personal choice to avoid words that cause offense or poorly define others is one way to practice compassion and intercultural communication competence.

Galinsky, A. D., Hugenberg, K., Groom, C., & Bodenhausen, G. (2003) further examine how labels can be “reappropriated” to change the meaning of the word, if only for the person themselves:



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Given that to appropriate means “to take possession of or make use of exclusively for oneself,” we consider reappropriate to mean to take possession for oneself that which was once possessed by another, and we use it to refer to the phenomenon whereby a stigmatized group revalues an externally imposed negative label by selfconsciously referring to itself in terms of that label. Instead of passively accepting the negative connotative meanings of the label, ...[one can reject] those damaging meanings and through reappropriation imbued the label with positive connotations. By reappropriating this negative label, ...[one can seek] to renegotiate the meaning of the word, changing it from something hurtful to something empowering...[Such] actions imply two assumptions that are critical to reappropriation. First, names are powerful, and second, the meanings of names are subject to change and can be negotiated and renegotiated (p.222).

Reappropriation of language is often confusing and nebulous. As one mindfully decides (or not) to use terms in new ways, remember, many times others outside a peer group, co-culture or culture may not understand. For example, the true meaning of a female calling another female friend a “bitch” to reappropriate the term and give it a “hip” or “warrior-goddess” sound might be lost on the average passerby who might, then, believe it is acceptable for him or her to likewise use such language.

Verbal Communication Advice:

Most often, thinking before speaking is an adage one can benefit from taking. Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy (2017) offer additional advice as summarized below:



Life in Greece: Photo submitted by Jordan Wentz, used with permission

- Slow Down
 - The phrase, “The slower you go, the faster you go,” can apply to conversing with someone who does not share the same native language.
- Keep it Sweet and Simple (KISS)
 - English learners will appreciate clear, concise and concrete language choices — so will native English speakers. If one’s intercultural communication partner has limited shared language, simplicity helps both increase shared meaning. Remember, though, speaking louder does not help if one does not know the language. This generally becomes more insulting to the English learner and can become a barrier in the interview process.
- Research
 - If you can, research the language of the speaker prior to your interview.
- Listen Beyond Accents
 - A Minnesotan will speak with a different accent, generally, than a Mississippian. Remembering that we “all have accents” to individuals not from the same region or country helps to gain patience for the decoding process.
- Dialects are Distinctive
 - “Dialects not only identify someone as being from a certain region, but also are distinctive of a person’s country” (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017, p.274). Try not to be diverted by someone’s dialect.
- Use “I” Language to explain this is what “I” heard

- Good paraphrasing and perception checking begin with “I” language.
- So Many Questions?
 - While it sounds contradictory, preparation does not mean listing more questions than the interviewee has time to thoughtfully address without information overload. Sometimes, less is more. While preparation is helpful, decide upon a few key questions for the interview and keep open to the possibility of new topics coming up during the interview.
- Clarify Expectations
 - Ensure both you and the interview share the same meaning for the interview.
- Avoid Slang and Idioms
 - Remember there is a difference between connotative (commonly/emotionally powered meanings) and denotative (more dictionary based and “proper”) meanings. Individuals speaking in a second language, initially, rely more on the denotative meaning of a term as they learn the new language.
 - The meaning one has by using slang is often connotatively confusing between co-cultures (age, race, region); it’s best to avoid.
 - “By definition, idioms are a group of words that when used together have a particular meaning different from the sum of the meanings of the individual words in isolation. Hence, idioms are not capable of literal translation” (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017, p.276).
- Recognize Argot
 - Argot is a “...specialized informal language used by people who are affiliated with a particular co-culture. This dedicated vocabulary serves two main purposes. First, it is an in-group and secret language. While ‘outsiders’ may understand the language and even try to use it, it is, nevertheless, part of the domain of the co-culture. Second, the language establishes a strong sense of identity, as it is associated only with members of the co-culture” (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017, pp.274-275).

This page titled [1.5: Verbal Communication](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente \(Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project\)](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

1.6: Listening

Listening and Compassionate Listening

If we can change ourselves, we can change the world...This is the essence of compassionate listening: seeing the person next to you as part of yourself...As the Compassionate Listening Project has pointed out, when you approach a moment without judgment and can connect with the sacredness of the agency of each soul, we can transform the moment...[and] evolve.
~ Rep. Dennis Kucinich (Hoffman, 2013, p.317)

Chapter Overview

Not knowing how to listen, neither can they speak. ~ Heraclitus



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Listening seems like an automatic process. However, though it is a process, it is far from automatic or obvious. This chapter will define listening and distinguish different skills for improving one's intercultural communication.

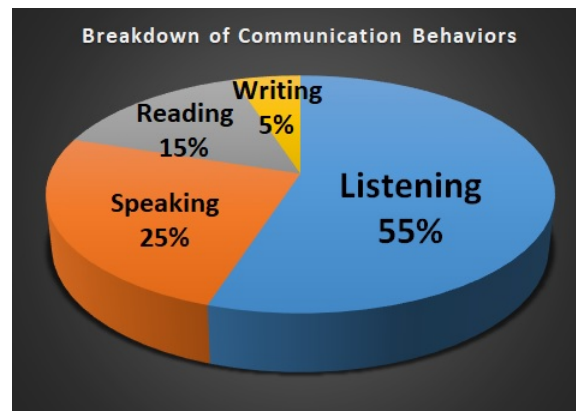
Listening Defined

"Listening is the learned process of receiving, interpreting, recalling, evaluating, and responding to verbal and nonverbal messages" (Communication, 2016, p.230). Listening is a choice whereas hearing is a physiological action. Further, listening is a skill one can cultivate. Notice, though, that the interpretation of how, and hence whether, you are listening may be seen through a cultural lens. For example, giving eye contact in an American context would be seen as direct – but not a "stare down." Yet, direct gazes in many cultures are seen as inappropriate. The ability to observe and adapt to the communication partner will be useful in an intercultural communication conversation or interview. Consider the many questions going through one's head: "Is my partner looking down—maybe I should look away?" "Is this person giving me, the stare down?" Listening skills take time to cultivate and interpretation of the message, is tough. Learning the skills of active and compassionate listening, though, assists one in developing intercultural communication competence.

The Process of Listening

Intercultural communication, like all communication, seeks to share and understand meaning in diverse settings. Below, Green, Keith Green, Fairchild, Knudsen & Lease-Gubrud (2018) explain the process of listening in the materials accessed from their creative commons OER book, *Introduction to Communication: A Free, Open-Source, Introductory Communication Studies Text*:

Human relationships are built on communication. As we speak and listen, learn about each other, and get to know each other in personal ways, relationships grow and thrive. Our relationships are defined by how we communicate, including what we talk about, when we talk about it, and how we respond. The substance of relationships is how we communicate. Interaction is comprised of what we tell each other (disclosure) and how we attend to each other's disclosure (listening).



(Green, Fairchild, Knudsen & Lease-Gubrud, 2018 – Image 1)

We engage in four communication behaviors: listening, speaking, reading and writing. Of these four, listening is by far the most frequently used. According to the International Listening Association, ‘**Listening** is the process of receiving, constructing meaning from, and responding to spoken and/or nonverbal messages’ (Verderber and MacGeorge, p.197).

Ever since the first major study to assess listening time, the Rankin study of 1926, researchers have looked at how we use each of these behaviors within our overall communication package (Brownell, 2010). Taking into account a range of studies since Rankin, we can estimate the breakdown of our communication behaviors as shown in Image 1. The specific distribution of our individual communication behaviors will change daily and according to variables such as jobs, interests, and activities.

An interesting contrast is the time we spend on learning each of these behaviors which is directly inverted to the time we spend on each. From kindergarten to college we take classes on improving writing ability. We are taught how to read well into high school. High school students spend significantly less time learning public speaking than they do reading and writing. Listening, which is the most commonly used communication behavior, is rarely taught as a unique, identifiable skill.

Listening is the most relational of all our communication behaviors. How we listen to another affects our relationships more than anything else we do. Too often we focus on what to say, when in actuality we need to focus far more on just listening to what the other person is saying. When others focus on us, attending to what we have to say, and really listening and understanding our concerns, they are giving us a powerful message of worth and value (Green, Fairchild, Knudsen & Lease-Gubrud, 2018, Module 5, Section 1).

Active Listening



LISTEN: Halverson-Wente photograph, used with permission

“Active listening refers to the process of pairing outwardly visible positive listening behaviors with positive cognitive listening practices. Active listening can help address many of the environmental, physical, cognitive, and personal barriers to effective listening... The behaviors associated with active listening can also enhance informational, critical, and empathetic listening” (Communication, 2016).

Some basic skills related to active listening include:

1. Use of “I” statements to show the speaker that any reflection is “yours” and, as such, an interpretation.

2. Nonverbally, active listeners try to, “SOFTEN” the communication situation to show nonverbally that one is listening. SOFTEN refers to the use of a **S**mile, **O**pen Posture, **F**acial Expressions, **T**ouch (by shaking hands or another appropriate manner), **E**ye Contact, **N**ods (Wassmer, 1978).
3. Reply with a paraphrase (or restatement in your own words) to show one is listening and to clarify the message.

These three areas tend to be traditional skills when discussing active listening. However, some scholars in “Compassion Studies” stress the need to just listen without stopping the conversation or redirecting it.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Listening is part of the third component of intercultural communication competence—the other two competencies being motivation (motivated to do what is necessary for a successful intercultural communication encounter) and possessing a certain level of knowledge about other cultures (Samovar, Porter, McDaniel, & Roy, 2017; Lustig and Koestler, 2010). Though listed under the component of skills, the practice of which make intercultural communication encounters more successful, listening is certainly part of all three components of intercultural communication competence. Keep in mind, though, that culture affects listening. For example, different cultures put different values on listening in their communication process. Many Asian cultures hold that words may clutter one’s understanding; silence, then, is often valued over talking—consider the Buddhist expression, “There is a truth that words cannot reach.”

Active Listening Tips for Intercultural Communication Situations



Rochester Diversity Council photo, used with permission

Listening is active and is part and parcel of effective and sensitive perception checking that moves the conversation forward and demonstrates effective intercultural communication competence. While remembering each culture possesses unique communication norms, expectations, and behaviors, McLean (2018) shares some general tips to facilitate active listening and reading:

- Maintain eye contact with the speaker when culturally appropriate.
 - Don’t interrupt.
 - Focus your attention on the message and how it is said, not your internal monologue.
 - Restate the message in your own words and ask if you understood correctly.
 - Ask clarifying questions to communicate interest and gain insight
- (McLean, 2018, Section 2.6).

Compassionate Listening

The concept of compassionate listening (in the literature, akin to mindfulness or empathy), it is argued, is a particularly effective listening posture—a touchstone for effective intercultural communication that enables one to respectfully communicate and learn with a profound richness and depth in an intercultural/diverse setting. Compassionate listening sometimes is called, “empathic” listening. However, compassionate listening is much more than showing empathy.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Empathy is a gateway to compassion. It’s understanding how someone feels, and trying to imagine how that might feel for you — it’s a mode of relating. Compassion takes it further. It’s feeling what that person is feeling, holding it, accepting it, and taking some kind of action. In metta or loving-kindness meditation practice, one can silently repeat phrases to others as a way of acknowledging them and our own interconnectedness. It’s easy and highly portable. When I’m on the train, I silently repeat phrases like, “May you be happy; may you be safe; may you be at ease; may you be free from suffering,” to the passengers, particularly those who look like they need it most. This plants the seeds of compassion, and we can find ourselves acting in compassionate ways that never would have occurred to us before. As it turns out, this ancient practice has some amazing scientific discoveries to give it cred (Chandler, n.d.).

Thich Nhat Hanh, a Vietnamese Buddhist monk and Nobel Peace Prize winner, asserts compassionate (deep) listening moves beyond a mere interaction. Compassionate listening can be used, he claims, to help end suffering for individuals and societies. He discussed his notion of compassionate listening during an interview with Oprah Winfrey (Oprah Winfrey Network, 2012):

Deep listening is the kind of listening that can help relieve the suffering of another person. You can call it compassionate listening. You listen with only one purpose: to help him or her to empty his heart. Even if he says things that are full of wrong perceptions, full of bitterness, you are still capable of continuing to listen with compassion. Because you know that listening like that, you give that person a chance to suffer less. If you want to help him to correct his perception, you wait for another time. For now, you don’t interrupt. You don’t argue. If you do, he loses his chance. You just listen with compassion and help him to suffer less. One hour like that can bring transformation and healing.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Practicing self-care complements compassionate listening. Compassion is simply defined as showing care to someone who suffers. Often, listening to someone who “suffers” offers a true lifeline; however, it can also be draining and exhausting to the listener. Others might say it is renewing. It is a different sort of listening and one not shared often in communication classes. One must understand, too, that not ALL situations call for compassionate or deep listening. Sometimes a paraphrase is just fine. Listening to someone you disagree with or hearing someone share a viewpoint on complex and controversial topics such as “Black Lives Matter” / “All Lives Matter” or standing/kneeling for the flag can take on a personal aspect that may thwart civil discussion. Dismissing the urge to “correct” can be difficult.

To practice “deep listening” Rome (2010) suggests one must prepare physically as well as intellectually for compassionate listening. Rome’s article (<https://www.mindful.org/deep-listening/>) lists several activities one can practice to increase mindful listening.



Creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Deep Listening involves listening, from a deep, receptive, and caring place in oneself, to deeper and often subtler levels of meaning and intention in the other person. It is listening that is generous, empathic, supportive, accurate, and trusting. Trust here does not imply agreement, but the trust that whatever others say, regardless of how well or poorly it is said, comes from something true in their experience. Deep Listening is an ongoing practice of suspending self-oriented, reactive thinking and opening one’s awareness to the unknown and unexpected (Rome, 2010).

Again, a basic approach to listening reminds us that sometimes “less is more” when it comes to “being there” for a friend or stranger. McLean (2018), as noted below, offers the following tips to facilitate listening and conversation, helping one be in the moment when things get tough:

- Set aside a special time. To have a difficult conversation or read bad news, set aside a special time when you will not be disturbed. Close the door and turn off the television, music player, and instant messaging client.
- Don’t interrupt. Keep silent while you let the other person “speak his [or her] piece.” If you are reading, make an effort to understand and digest the news without mental interruptions.
- Be nonjudgmental. Receive the message without judgment or criticism. Set aside your opinions, attitudes, and beliefs.
- Be accepting. Be open to the message being communicated, realizing that acceptance does not necessarily mean you agree with what is being said.
- Take turns. Wait until it is your turn to respond, and then measure your response in proportion to the message that was delivered to you. Reciprocal turn taking allows each person have his or her say.
- Acknowledge. Let the other person know that you have listened to the message or read it attentively.
- Understand. Be certain that you understand what your partner is saying. If you don’t understand, ask for clarification. Restate the message in your own words.
- Keep your cool. Speak your truth without blaming. A calm tone will help prevent conflict from escalating. Use “I” statements (e.g., “I felt concerned when I learned that my department is going to have a layoff”) rather than “you” statements (e.g., “You want to get rid of some of our best people”) (McLean, 2018, Section 2.6).

This page titled [1.6: Listening](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente](#) and [Mark Halverson-Wente](#) (Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Intercultural Communication Interview Essay

[2.1: Sample Essays](#)

[2.2: Grading Rubric](#)

[2.3: Sample Outline 1 – Exploring 3 Different Aspects of a Co-Culture](#)

[2.4: Sample Outline 2](#)

This page titled [2: Intercultural Communication Interview Essay](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente \(Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project\)](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

2.1: Sample Essays



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

This essay is shared with permission from the author

XXXX

Halverson-Wente

COMM 2100

6 November 2017

The Little Hmong House

It was Friday night. I was up in the Twin Cities spending the night at a friend's house since we both had early morning dance practice the next day. He was always kind enough to offer the option of staying over at his place the night before instead of commuting unreasonably early on Saturday mornings for practice, so there I was at his place on a Friday night, helping him set the dinner table. Just as I was about to lay the spoons into the rice bowls, I heard him shout out quickly and scramble over to stop me. "Don't lay the spoons in there," he hollered. Stopping in my tracks, I began to wonder why that was. As it turns out, in the Hmong culture he came from, utensils are only set in rice bowls as an offering to the dead. The majority of my friends in the Twin Cities are Hmong, so having been exposed to so much of their culture already, I was interested in exploring more. I had the honor of growing closer to these friends who were very passionate and knowledgeable of their Hmong roots, and I found myself delving even deeper into their heritage through conversations and experience. In the past month, I've collected knowledge on Hmong perception of family and power distance, the effect of Hmong language on views of the world, and Hmong nonverbal and verbal communication.

As I interviewed XXX, one of my Hmong friends in St. Paul, I learn more about their perceptions on family and power distance. Because traditional Hmong families value collectivism, people outside of their family are perceived as negative forces. For example, a lot of Hmong families that have immigrated to the U.S. are still very reluctant to trust the American medical system or rely on prescriptions. They would much rather use people within their families as resources for treating medical conditions and providing herbal medication (Nancy, 2017). The Hmong and their perceptions on family are even more complex in that they are separated into clans by last name, and each of these clans have developed perceptions of people, events, truths, or decision making based on their history as explained in the book (p. 218). One day, my friends told me common behaviors about certain families do or not do such as "...members of the Yang family are not allowed to eat chicken heart" or some families feud for more than hundreds of years based on name (XXX, 2017). These perceptions on family also play a role in the power distance in Hmong families. Status in the families are described as a hierarchy. As explained in the book, people of hierarchy-based cultures believe "power and authority are facts of life" in families or societies (p.227-28). Americans do not have huge power distances amongst people because growing up I've been taught about "equality", but according to Teng Moua, elders have more power than the youth and the men have more power than the women (2003). An example of keeping this hierarchy would be how family members are addressed. When a family member enters the home, they are respectfully addressed by their relation (Aunt, Uncle, Cousin, etc.) then addressed by their first name. Subtle it may be, the detail reinforces the hierarchy system. Perception, values, and power distance in the Hmong community affect their social life through language.

The language spoken by the Hmong changes their views of the world. According to the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis, language is not a way of reporting an experience, but language is a way of defining an experience (p. 271). I find it true when two languages have an abundance of words that cannot translate to one another. This epiphany helped me understand the concept between language and perception, for they are used interchangeably to define experiences happening to an individual. For example, Americans have a strong belief system in science and can gather the facts, statistics, and data to define "sleep paralysis", but due to their spiritual roots, in Hmong, the word is nonexistent and the Hmong therefore have a different definition for the experience. Two different cultures with two different perceptions define the same experience in their own way. Since traditional Hmong families practice

Shamanism, the religion contributes to the language. Shamanism involves people connecting, perceiving, and interacting with the spirit world. As I mentioned America's definition of "sleep paralysis", Hmong Shamans would define the experience as "an evil spirit sitting on your chest." I also had the opportunity to visit some Hmong households who practice Shamanism, and their shrines can be a simple table or a massive shed. According to several of my Hmong friends, the slightest mispronunciation in the Hmong language could cause miscommunication. Not only does the Hmong language differ from other cultures, they also have different dialects. They have dialects such as "Hmong Red", "Hmong Blue", "Hmong Green", or "Hmong Black" in the community, and each dialect has their own rules or pronunciations. However, it is not uncommon for speakers of the same language to have difficulties understanding each other (p.273-74). The Hmong language has sensitive vocabulary that can have one word contain five definitions by the slightest pronunciation. I've been told the best example is to say, "My mother likes to steal money" to see the tongue twisting phrase. Even though the language contributes to their worldview, knowing the combinations of Hmong nonverbal and verbal communication should be an expectation in families.

According to my interview with Nancy, Hmong nonverbal and verbal communication is passive-aggressive. When I started dating my girlfriend, I had to meet her parents for the first time. Although her mother never directly expressed her disliking of my silver hair at the time, she did make sure to get it across that "black hair is the most beautiful hair color". The Hmong are less apt to verbally express their personal thoughts and opinions openly, as they are very cautious of ruining their reputation. Instead they carefully choose their words to discreetly let someone know of their intentions. With the situation with my girlfriend's mother, she never once uttered a derogatory comment pertaining to my hair color, but I was still able to understand that she was not the biggest fan of the color. Just as it states in the book, a person's definition of attractiveness can be related to the "particular culture in which they live" (pg.297). In the Hmong culture, black hair is preferred because it is considered pure and authentic (Nancy, 2017). While passive aggressiveness is a reoccurring theme with verbal communication, it is also present in nonverbal communication. In this case, it can be displayed with the nonverbal tasks that are expected from the younger generations by elders. If you are a man at a social gathering such as a wedding or funeral, you are expected to deliver a proper greeting and handshake to every man older than you. To not follow through with these actions would send the unintentional message that you do not respect the elders (Nancy, 2017). Actions like these are expected without any instruction, so there may be cases where failure to act could come across as an "unintentional act" of disrespect. In fact, "nonverbal messages are most often produced without a conscious awareness" which often leaves room for misunderstanding (pg.297). The elders would take the inability to greet as a sign of disrespect when really it could have simply been ignorance.

Since discovering the Hmong community thriving in the Twin Cities, I've gathered knowledge on Hmong perception of family and power distance, the effect of Hmong language on views of the world, and Hmong nonverbal and verbal communication. I've learned how much a single culture can impact a means of communication, and it's brought out an understanding inside of me when conversing with people. Everyone comes from a different background. What I may view as a polite gesture might actually be rude to another person due to their cultural upbringing. Although my cultural awareness has broadened, this is only a mild stepping stone to learning even more about how cultural roots play an important role in the way someone may communicate.

WORKS CITED

XXX. "Hmong Culture." 4 Nov. 2017.

Moua, Teng. "THE HMONG CULTURE: KINSHIP, MARRIAGE & FAMILY SYSTEMS." May 2003, <file:///C:/Users/ryanl/AppData/Local.../2003mouat.pdf>.

Samovar, Larry A., et al. *Communication between cultures*. Boston, MA, Cengage Learning.

This page titled [2.1: Sample Essays](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente \(Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project\)](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

2.2: Grading Rubric



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Intercultural Communication Essay Grading Rubric

Understanding how you will be graded on your essay will be helpful as you organize your ideas and decide where to place the emphasis. As you will see below (and in the assignment sheet), the essay is about combining your own experience, observations and insight with concepts you are learning in this Unit.

Intercultural Communication Interview Essay Grading Rubric

Description You scored a _____ on the rubric this equals _____ points out of 10

5 = You met the criteria for the assignment: You did what was asked of in the paper assignment and did fully summarize the topic you chose, etc. Your description was detailed and you gave full examples of the concept/theory you were explaining from personal observation, experience and/or reflection. Your responses showed complex and thoughtful detail. You gave specific examples to illustrate your points. You described what you personally learned from this experience. This assignment included time spent with a person or place related to this culture.

4 = You met the criteria for the assignment: you did summarize the topic you explored. Your description was detailed and you gave examples of the concept/theory you were explaining. You gave examples to illustrate your points. You described what you personally learned from this experience. Your descriptions could have been a bit more detailed.

3 = You met the criteria for the assignment and did describe the topic you chose. You did give examples of the concept or theory you were describing, but at times this was brief. Your responses should have showed more thoughtful detail. Your examples to illustrate your points could have been more detailed. You described what you personally learned from this experience. Paper was a bit brief.

2 = Your descriptions were very brief. Your ties between experience and theory were often foggy due the lack of description. Your paper was most likely brief (and short) due to the lack of details.

1 = Very little description was given. Your paper was much too brief.

0 = You did not describe what you did to any significant degree. Perhaps you listed definitions without any descriptions.

Analysis

You scored a _____ on the rubric this equals
_____points out of 10

5 = You did go well beyond description! The paper thoughtfully and critically assessed the topic overall, describing how and most importantly “why” the theory explains the topic. You made connections between theory and experience that show creativity and critical thinking. Definitions and quotes were used to create unique insight into your topic. Personal reflection was used in addition to analytical critic based upon theory. It was clear that you analyzed your topic from an intercultural communication perspective. This essay required at LEAST 1 research article from a primary or academic source. Your integration of outside research was strong with correct citations and reference to the materials.

4 = You did go beyond description and did assess your topic. You did show a connection between theory and experience but could have, in places, added more emphasis on “why” this occurs and/or “how” this topic is related to intercultural communication. Definitions were used to create insight into your experience. Personal reflection was used. More integration of the theory and topic could be made. Some ties to outside research was included, as well as proper citations.

3 = You did describe the topic/experience and did make some attempts at explaining “why” this was important and “why” this occurs. However many explanations were brief and could have been more in depth. The analysis was based more upon personal experience than ties to theory. Definitions were used but did not offer unique insight concerning intercultural communication. Some theory was mentioned, but often was more “added” than fully integrated into the explanations and analysis. Some theory use was not fully correct.

2 = While you did describe what happened, the explanation of “why” this occurred was often brief and the paper focused more upon stating what the topic is and/or “what it is called” or it was based more upon personal experience. At times theory use was not fully correct.

1 = Weak analysis. The paper was mostly descriptive, relied mostly upon personal opinion and lacked analytical emphasis.

0 = There was no focus upon theory or analysis in this paper. It did not meet the criteria.

Application of Theory

_____/5 pts.

5 = In your analysis and description, you thoughtfully integrated the theory from the text at least 5 times and cited the sources correctly (page reference)? Furthermore, there was a purposeful connection between your experience/observations/examples and analysis/theory. Strong synthesis and connection was also made with the research/primary source article.

4 = In your analysis and description, you did integrate the theory correctly at least 5 times. There was a clear connection between theory and experience/observation/examples. However, the connection should have been integrated and synthesized further. The theory use was correct but could have been a deeper use. Strong connection was also made with the research/primary source article.

3 = You did correctly label the experience/observation/examples with the theory. However, you did not always explain how the theory connected to the experience. Some connection was also made with the research/primary source article.

2 = You did include some theory in your paper, but not 5 full citations. Your connections were loosely related and not explained in many instances. Research from outside research was mentioned but not cited correctly and not fully integrated.

1 = Theory seemed merely placed in the paper without any meaningful connection. A source was listed but it was unclear when and where the outside research was used.

0 = You did not cite the text 5 times. No outside research was used.

TOTAL SCORE:

This page titled [2.2: Grading Rubric](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente](#) and [Mark Halverson-Wente](#) (Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

2.3: Sample Outline 1 – Exploring 3 Different Aspects of a Co-Culture

Sample Outlines



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Each of the following outlines are merely ideas to “get started.” Look over the assignment, consider what your personal interest is, then see how you might modify the outlines below or start your own idea. Please contact your instructor if you need help getting started.

Idea 1- Exploring 3 different aspects of a co-culture

Sample Outline – You are welcome to create your essay in another format. Again, this is your paper – you can just go out and explore – even go dancing, taste the food and have a conversation, listen to music.

I. Introduction

- a. Attention
- b. What you did and why
- c. Topic/basic overview of your focus/key terms identified
- d. Thesis/Preview

II. Body

- a. What is this culture and how does it use _____ [Food?]
 - i. Describe what the research says
 - ii. What did you observe
 - iii. How does this relate to the chapter on nonverbal communication?
 - iv. What did you learn?
 - v. Synthesis/take away.
- b. What is this culture and how does it use _____ [Music?]
 - i. Describe what the research says
 - ii. What did you observe
 - iii. How does this relate to the chapter on nonverbal communication?
 - iv. What did you learn?
 - v. Synthesis/take away.
- c. What is this culture and how does it use _____ [Dance?]
 - i. Describe what the research says
 - ii. What did you observe
 - iii. How does this relate to the chapter on nonverbal communication?
 - iv. What did you learn?
 - v. Synthesis/take away.

d. As you now compare your experience to your own intercultural personhood, what do you hope to learn in the future?

III. Conclusion:

a. Summary

b. Memorable End

This page titled [2.3: Sample Outline 1 – Exploring 3 Different Aspects of a Co-Culture](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente \(Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project\)](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

2.4: Sample Outline 2

Idea 2: Intercultural Interview

This is a general approach to the topic to explore the ideas from any of our speakers.



creative commons photo from burst.shopify.com

Introduction

- Attention:
 - During a guest speaker's presentation in class, I heard the speaker say...
 - The examples of how language and intercultural communication are related included:
- Topic Revealed
 - These examples helped me better see why language, or verbal communication is defined as _____ (CITATION)
 - To me, this means....
 - It is not easy to define, but I believe..... (narrow and set up your thesis)
- Thesis/Preview

Language can confine and define, this can provide challenges and rewards. Specifically:

Transition

Body

- Part 1: Defining Terms — Culture, Language and Intercultural Communication:
 - Culture
 - Define Terms: Several definitions for _____ [culture in this outline] are included in the book that offer insight into the nature of this term.
 1. According to _____, culture is defined as. “_____” (CITATION).
 2. Paraphrase/Explain Citation: When I read this definition, I think _____.
 3. The definition explains: _____.
 - Language/Verbal Communication:
 1. According to _____, language [or verbal communication] is defined as, “_____” (CITATION).
 2. Paraphrase/Explain Citation: When I read this definition, I think _____.
 3. The definition explains: _____.
 - The “Nexus” of Culture, Language and Intercultural Communication Means:
 1. According to _____, the three terms intersect in such a way... “_____” (CITATION).
 2. Paraphrase/Explain Citation: When I read this definition, I think _____.
 3. The definition explains: _____.
 4. Synthesis and Section Conclusion: These definitions show that...
 1. Tie to Essay Prompt/Personalize: I have experienced a variety challenges and rewards using language with a variety of cultures including.....
 2. Paragraph Conclusion: THERFORE, I believe thatabout language and intercultural communication.
- More about a culture I interacted with:

1. For this assignment, I interacted with the culture/co-culture of:
 1. Describe
 2. What happened?
 2. The Outside Research I conducted indicates that: explain/cite sources.
 3. From this research I wanted to learn:
 4. Testing it out: to learn more, I explored the culture by ...and applied the following terms:
 1. Term-Example-Your Interpretation/Take away about this concept.
 2. Term-Example- Your Interpretation/Take away about this concept.
 3. Term-Example- Your Interpretation/Take away about this concept.
 5. Synthesis and section conclusion.
- From this experience, I learned that:
 1. What I have learned about myself.
 1. Explain
 2. Example(s)
 3. Tie back to terms/conclusion.
 2. What I want to explore about others.
 1. Explain
 2. Example(s)
 3. Tie back to terms/conclusion.

Conclusion

- Summary
- Concluding remarks

This page titled [2.4: Sample Outline 2](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente](#) ([Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project](#)) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Communicating with Co-Cultures

- 3.1: Guest 1 – Meet Michael and Learn about the LGBTQA+ Community
- 3.2: Guest 2 – Meet Meet Kim Sin and learn about the Cambodian-American Community
- 3.3: Guest 3 – Meet Al Lun and Learn more about being a “Permanent Other”
- 3.4: Guest 3 – Meet Chao Mwatela, RCTC Multicultural Advisor
- 3.6: Guest 5 – Meet Laura, RCTC Student and Human Library Volunteer

This page titled [3: Communicating with Co-Cultures](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente](#) and [Mark Halverson-Wente](#) (Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

3.1: Guest 1 – Meet Michael and Learn about the LGBTQA+ Community

Module 1 – LGBTQ+

Intercultural Communication Speaker Series – Meet Michael

Michael took COMM 2100 in 2019 and returned as a Research Assistant student worker in the Summer of 2020. We are excited Michael will continue studies in Communication at the University of MN but sad to see this great RCTC Grad go!

Michael still volunteers to share lived experiences as a Trans Male. Please watch Michael's video:



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

Learn more about LGBTQ+ Topics

Language Use: Initialisms and Vocabulary



Initialism...

Initialisms

The LGBTQ+ community is comprised of a group of individuals who identify as Lesbian (L), Gay (G), Bisexual (B), Transgender or Nonconforming (T), Queer (Q), and others (+). The symbol “+” is used to indicate that more sexual orientations/identities may be included. The basis for initialisms lies with the concept of nonbinary gender identity. These initialisms, in short, help to “move beyond the binary.”

Now, **binary** refers to either-or, 2 possible choices – much like a bicycle has 2 tires, “male or female” is an example of a binary choice. However, “throughout history, some people have identified as neither male nor female, or as ‘nonbinary’....**Nonbinary** people’s gender identity lies outside the boundaries of a strict male–female dichotomy” (National Institute of Health, 2020)

Additional initialisms include LGBT, LGBT+, LGBTQ, LGBTQ+, where an “I” is included for individuals who are intersexual, an “A” includes individuals who are A-sexual (or, some might claim, Allies). LGBTTTQIA is a more recent initialism of lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, transsexual, queer, questioning, intersex, asexual, allies, and pansexual. Reid-Smith points out that “[s]ome people wrongly think LGBT or LGBTQ are acronyms. In fact, he continues, initial letters are only an acronym if you say them as a word, like “NASA.” Therefore LGBT+ and all the other options are initialisms, because you spell out each letter, like you do in the USA” (2020).



Literally, an umbrella!

Reid-Smith (2020) asserts that “all of the options are umbrella terms for the same community..[t]hey broadly mean the same.” The interesting part is that adding more letters means one is thereby “explicitly including more identities. On face value, that makes your choice more overtly inclusive. In a like manner, “using the ‘+’ symbol is a more implicit way of doing that. Thus, by “adding the plus, you include everyone else” without having to season a rich, thick alphabet soup of dizzying letter combinations.

Reid-Smith cautions us to “remember that many people feel their own identities are overlooked within our community...” commenting that, “[a]fter all, the initialisms don’t contain ‘pansexual’, ‘non-binary’ or many more. So why stop at just LGBTQ?” Reid-Smith concludes that, simply, the “truth is there is no option that everyone agrees with. And some LGBTQ+ people actively dislike some of the choices” (2020).

So, why the alphabet soup? Tris Reid-Smith’s (2020) commentary reflects the complexity of initialism:

“...And if you want a ‘house style’ on how to express ‘LGBT+’, understand there are pros and cons to all the options and no right answer. So do your best and be prepared to listen and change as the community moves on. But most importantly, always remember our community is made up of 460 million individuals – so reflect their identities and respect their individuality in everything you do.”



Have a conversation about what initialism others choose.

LGBTQ+

At this juncture, initialized notions of co-cultures and communities might seem unfamiliar or foreign. As you learn more, you can ask individuals about the version of the initialism they use. For the purposes of this textbook, we will use that initialism [OutFront Minnesota](#) ascribes to due to their 30+ years of leadership and committed activism in this area: LGBTQ+. For further relevant reading, please consult the many links below:

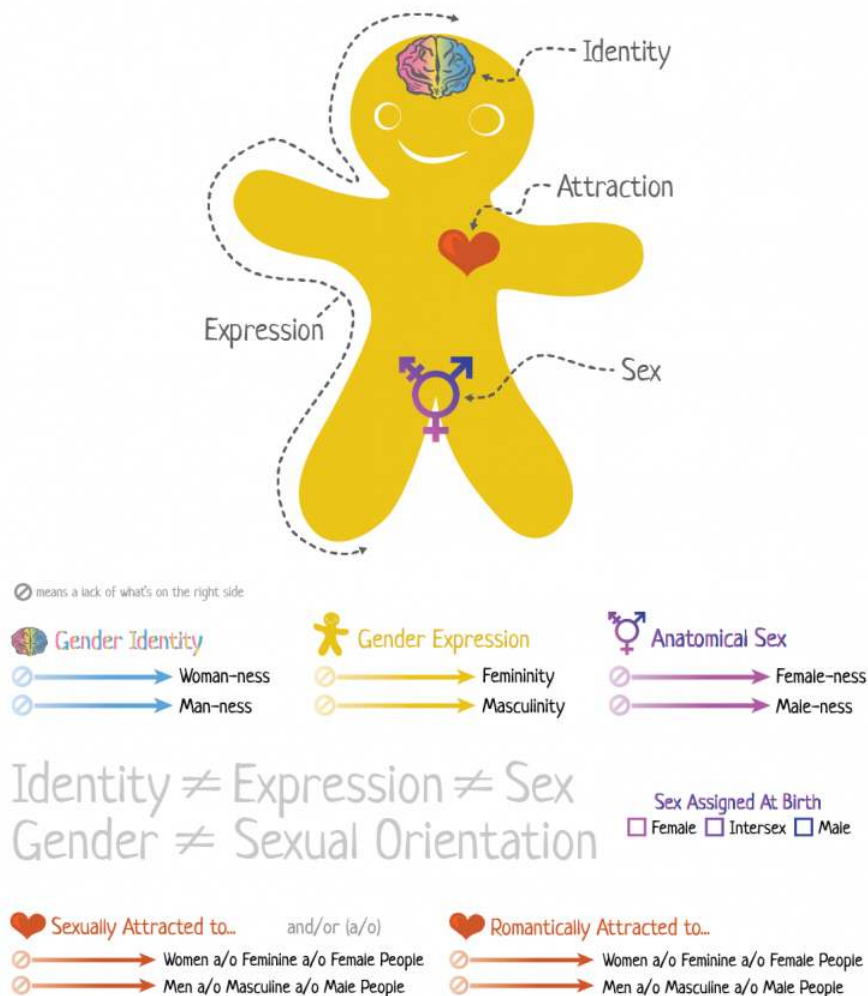
- <https://www.itspronouncedmetrosexual.com/2013/01/a-comprehensive-list-of-lgbtq-term-definitions/>
- <https://www.glaad.org/reference#guide>
- <https://www.minnstate.edu/system/equity/glossary.html>
- <https://www.uis.edu/gendersexualitystudentservices/about/lgbtqaterminology/>
- <https://lgbtqia.ucdavis.edu/educated/glossary>
- <https://www.gaystarnews.com/article/lgbttqia2s-letters-mean/#gs.999vgk>
- American Psychological Association

Language Choice: Presenting the “Genderbread Person”



Understanding the language in this unit, and the changes that have occurred since you had “the BIG sex talk” in middle or even elementary school are daunting. Back in the 1970’s we watched an animated show, one for the boys and one for the girls. A lot has changed since. The “Genderbread Person,” created by Sam Killermann, is an effort to bring about positive change as an “educational tool to clarify the distinctions among gender assigned at birth, experienced gender, and sexual orientation” (IACAPAP.org, 2018). Below is a copy of the Genderbread Person shared under Killermann’s [uncopyright policy](#).

The Genderbread Person v4 *by its pronounced METROsexual owner*



Genderbread Person Version 4 created and uncopyrighted 2017 by Sam Killermann For a bigger bite, read more at www.genderbread.org

This image and the explanations embedded in the graphic are used to leave the binaries of male/female, feminine/masculine, and gay/straight behind. As one blogger shares, “Binary language only accounts for two possible sides (boy & girl, gay & straight, Pepsi & Coke, dogs & cats), all while devaluing any other possibilities (transboy & cisgirl, bisexual & pansexual, Sierra Mist & Dr. Pepper, fish & birds)” ([neatmessy.blog, 2020](#)).

For Killermann, the “Genderbread Person is a model that depicts the ways society constructs gender, and the different components that go into that. It’s meant to be a digestible introduction to these ideas, for beginners, in a way that makes sense to most people” (Killermann, 2020).

Killermann (2020) states, as directly quoted below, the Genderbread Person is not :

- A depiction of how an idealized, or utopian society, might construct gender. Nor is it prescriptive, suggesting that gender _should be a certain way.
- A diagnostic tool to be used on or applied to other people in your life.
- A comprehensive model of sexuality or sexual orientation. While it includes orientation, this is in the spirit of helping to understand how it intersects with gender (i.e., There are _far _more than two forms of attraction, and/or people experience attraction and are oriented in many ways that are not just about gender).

Katie Couric Interviews Sam Killermann



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

The video above shares interesting information about the “Genderbread Person” from a 2017 interview between Katie Couric and Sam Killermann. Please note that, in the video, Killermann is referring to the 3.0 version of the Genderbread Person diagram and uses the concepts (contestable for many) of biological sex vs. anatomical sex. The fourth version of the handout highlights the differences between Gender Identity, Gender Expression, and Anatomical Sex.

- To learn more about Killermann’s work, see: <https://www.itspronouncedmetrosexual.com/2018/10/the-genderbread-person-v4/>
- For more information and a valuable glossary highlighting and complimenting the “Genderbread Person, please also see: <https://www.itspronouncedmetrosexual.com/2013/01/a-comprehensive-list-of-lgbtq-term-definitions/>

Module 2:

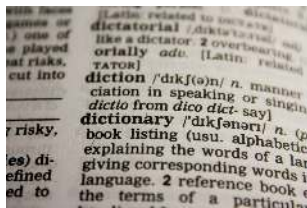
Sex, Sexual Orientation, Gender Expression, or Gender Identity? What’s the Difference?

Better Understanding the Difference between Sexual Orientation & Gender Identity

To better understand the concepts related to Killermann’s Genderbread Person, this video expands upon the phrases, “sex characteristics” versus “biological sex” or “anatomical sex.”

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C63Xn-i13o>

Definitions:



Dictionary Says...

Having gained a baseline of concepts, the following terms will help expand that base of information. Kelly Holstine, Director of Education Equity at OutFront Minnesota Education (and the 2018/19 Minnesota State Teacher of the Year) shared her academic expertise by allowing us to use the educational materials she has curated in the LGBTQ+ 101 & Intersectional Equity Training materials quoted, in their entirety, below:

Key Terms

- **Sex:** Category assigned at birth (female, male, or *intersex)
 - * People born with sex characteristics (including genitals, gonads, and chromosome patterns) “that do not fit typical binary notions of male or female bodies” (UN 2016). 1 in 1000 people (estimated)
- **Gender Identity:** Person’s internal sense of self (male, female, a blend of both, or neither)
- **Gender Expression:** The way people communicate their gender within a given culture (socially constructed: feminine, masculine, and/or other)
- **Sexual Orientation:** Sexual, romantic, and/or emotional attraction

Sexual Orientations

- **Lesbian:** A woman who is emotionally, physically, and/or sexually attracted to other women
- **Gay:** A man who is emotionally, physically, and/or sexually attracted to other men
- **Bisexual:** An individual who is emotionally, physically and/or sexually attracted to multiple sexes/genders
- **Asexual:** A term for those who do not feel physical or sexual attraction toward others
- **Pansexual:** A term for those with the capacity to be attracted to people of all genders (regardless of sex, gender identity, or expression)

Identities

- **Transgender:** A term for people whose gender identity differs from the sex they were assigned at birth
- **Queer:** An umbrella term used to describe anyone who is not straight, or the community as a whole
- **Two-spirit:** umbrella term used by some Indigenous North Americans to describe Native people in their communities who fulfill a traditional third-gender (or other gender-variant) ceremonial role in their cultures
- **Cisgender:** A term for people whose gender identity matches the sex they were assigned at birth
- **Gender NonConforming:** A term used for people whose gender expression differs from their gender identity
- **Nonbinary, genderfluid, or genderqueer:** a term used by some people who experience their gender identity and/or gender expression as falling outside of the categories of male or female

Thank you to Kelly Holstine for sharing the definitions she uses when leading training sessions.

The Relationship Between Biology & Sex



Biology & Sex – New Questions & Answers

A common question continues, “nature or nurture?” A conversation about biological sex was captured in a Ted Radio Hour program demonstrating that this is still not an easy question to address. The description reads, “Many of us were taught biological sex is a question of female or male, XX or XY ... but it’s far more complicated. This hour, TED speakers explore what determines our sex” ([National Public Radio, 2020](#)).

- Click here to listen: <https://www.npr.org/programs/ted-radio-hour/852195850/the-biology-of-sex?showDate=2020-05-08>

The following videos are highlighted in the NPR podcast noted above:

The way we think about biological sex is wrong, Emily Quinn

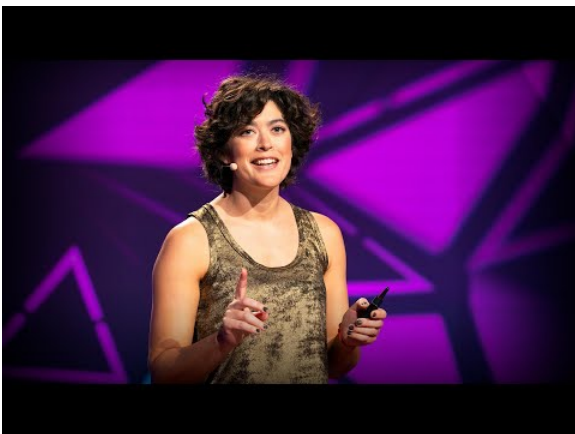
TED Description: “Did you know that almost 150 million people worldwide are born intersex — with biology that doesn’t fit the standard definition of male or female? (That’s as many as the population of Russia.) At age 10, Emily Quinn found out she was intersex, and in this wise, funny talk, she shares eye-opening lessons from a life spent navigating society’s thoughtless expectations, doctors who demanded she get unnecessary surgery — and advocating for herself and the incredible variety that humans come in. (Contains mature content).”



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

The weird history of the “sex chromosomes,” Molly Webster

TED Description: “The common thinking on biological sex goes like this: females have two X chromosomes in their cells, while males have one X and one Y. In this myth-busting talk, science writer and podcaster Molly Webster shows why the so-called “sex chromosomes” are more complicated than this simple definition — and reveals why we should think about them differently.”



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

The biology of gender, from DNA to the brain, Karissa Sanbonmatsu

TED Description: “How exactly does gender work? It’s not just about our chromosomes, says biologist Karissa Sanbonmatsu. In a visionary talk, she shares new discoveries from epigenetics, the emerging study of how DNA activity can permanently change based on social factors like trauma or diet. Learn how life experiences shape the way genes are expressed — and what that means for our understanding of gender.”



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

Your biology class and other scientists can continue the conversation with you concerning biological/anatomical sex. Listening to the podcasts and videos listed above, though, will help you formulate new questions about just how truly complex the opening lines to many of our lives were: “It’s a boy!” or “It’s a girl!”

Module Three: Skills for Inclusive Communication

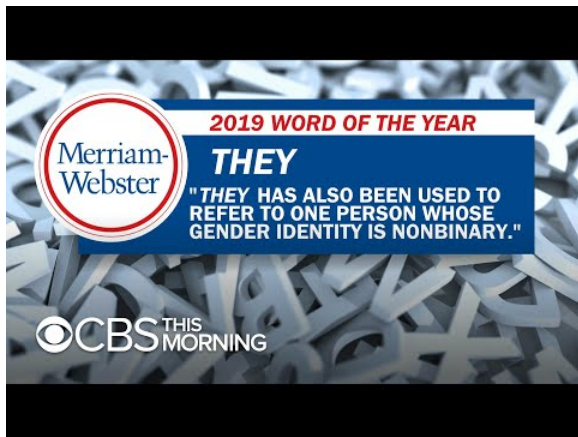
Singular They and Pronoun Use



**Ask, “What are your pronouns?” not,
“What are your preferred pronouns?”**

Changes in the understanding of gender and sex parallel changes in language. The American Psychological Association (APA), as well as the Modern Language Association (MLA), have updated their professional standards for writing. Though perhaps the single space after a period is groundbreaking for folks 50+, most scholars, journalists, and English teachers with red pens talked about the issue of using the singular “they” to substitute for the use of he or she (or he/she). The singular “they” became the Merriam-Webster Dictionary’s 2019 “Word of the Year.”

Nonbinary they takes a plural verb, despite referring to one person, which can make the grammatically conservative uncomfortable. It’s helpful to remember that the pronoun **you** was initially plural, which is why it too takes the plural verb even when it’s referring to a single person. “You are” has, of course, been perfectly grammatical for centuries, and it’s worth noting that thee and thou were long ago completely displaced by singular you in standard speech and writing—concrete evidence of the constant evolution of language. We don’t even notice the singular use of you today, and it’s quite possible that the nonbinary they is headed for a similarly unremarkable fate—only usage and time will tell ([Merriam-Webster, 2019](#))



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

For a 5 minute explanation on why “they” is the Word of the Year listen to: <https://www.npr.org/2019/12/13/787720675/the-word-of-the-year-is-they>

In addition to becoming the “Word of the Year,” the American Psychological Association endorsed the singular they. The APA suggests:

Use the following forms of the singular “they”:

Form	Example
they	Casey is a gender-fluid person. They are from Texas and enjoy tacos.
them	Every client got a care package delivered to them.
their	Each child played with their parent.
theirs	The cup of coffee is theirs.
themselves (or himself)	A private person usually keeps to themselves [or himself].

Also quoted fully below, the APA (2020) offers more suggestions for tips and alternatives.

“Here are some tips to help you use the proper forms:

- Use a plural verb form with the singular pronoun “they” (i.e., write “they are” not “they is”).
- Use a singular verb form with a singular noun (i.e., write “Casey is” or “a person is,” not “Casey are” or “a person are”).
- Both “themselves” and “themselves” are acceptable as reflexive singular pronouns; however, “themselves” is currently the more common usage.

Alternatives to the Generic Singular “They”

If using the singular “they” as a generic third-person pronoun seems awkward, try rewording the sentence or using the plural.

Strategy	Example
Rewording the sentence	I delivered a care package to the client.
Using the plural	Private people usually keep to themselves.

However, do not use alternatives when people use “they” as their pronoun—always use the pronouns that people use to refer to themselves (APA, 2020).

The University of Wisconsin, Madison shares advice and the following table (University of WI, Madison, 2020):

Pronouns	Nominative (subject)	Objective (object)	Possessive determiner	Possessive pronoun	Reflexive
they/them/ theirs	They write.	I wrote about them.	Their paper is excellent.	That paper is theirs.	They cited themselves.
ze/hir/hirs	Ze writes. ("zee")	I wrote about hir, ("heer")	Hir paper is excellent.	That paper is hirs. ("heers")	Ze cited about hirsself. ("heerself")
ze/zir/zirs	Ze writes. ("zee")	I wrote about zir, ("zeer")	Zir paper is excellent.	That paper is zirs. ("zeers")	Ze cited about zirself. ("zeerself")



What are your pronouns?

Pronouns Matter

Using the correct pronoun might take time to learn if the person has changed their name or pronoun use. Extensive advice is found at My Pronouns (<https://www.myprouns.org/>) where the following questions are addressed:

- **WHAT ARE PERSONAL PRONOUNS AND WHY DO THEY MATTER?**
- **HOW DO I USE PERSONAL PRONOUNS?**
- **WHAT IF SOMEONE MAKES A MISTAKE AND MISPRONOUNS SOMEONE ELSE?**
- **HOW DO I SHARE MY PERSONAL PRONOUNS?**
- **HOW DO I ASK SOMEONE THEIR PERSONAL PRONOUNS?**
- **HOW DO I USE GENDER INCLUSIVE LANGUAGE?**
- **WHAT ADDITIONAL RESOURCES AND LINKS CAN HELP ME?**

The following video shares why pronouns matter:



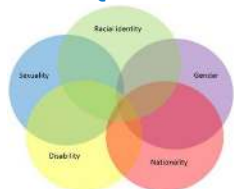
A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: <https://socialsci.libretexts.org/@go/page/79240>

This video shares addition views on the importance of pronouns:



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

Module 4: LGBTQ+: Intersectionality, Dominant Culture, and Co-Culture



Oppression is linked...

The Balance of Intersectionality, Dominant Culture, and Co-Culture

When considering co-cultures, one may easily succumb to the assumption that someone from a different co-culture than one's own would necessarily differ in categories and characteristics such as race, age, ethnic background. Some students looking to complete the co-culture interview assignment infer that there are attributes, readily observable, that identifies another as from a different co-culture. We are immersed within difference whether we can observe it or not. Conversely, one may also succumb to the assumption that those from one's own co-culture necessarily share the same behavioral traits, characteristics, and categories common to that co-culture. Both assumptions need to be avoided. The National LGBT Health Education Center (2020) shares that LGBT people, for example, "are from all different races, ethnicities, ages, social/economic classes, and places. Some in the community are very open about being LGB or T, while some are only "out" to a few people, or just to themselves. In short, one can "never be sure whether someone is LGBT unless they tell you" ([LGBT Health Education](#)).

The assumptions of difference and sameness above, in and of themselves, might possess some level of validity; however, given the concept of intersectionality—the "interconnected nature of social categorizations such as race, class, and gender as they apply to a given individual or group, regarded as creating [non-discrete] overlapping and interdependent systems of discrimination or disadvantage" (Oxford Dictionaries)—it is necessary to tread lightly about these assumptions. Case studies provide a demonstration of how individuals might belong simultaneously to a number of co-cultures such as "Julie," who identifies as lesbian, Christian, white, middle-class, and American. These five traits form an "intersection" of "overlapping and interdependent systems" which confer privilege/advantage, or conversely in other cases, as we'll next see, discrimination/disadvantage. Contrast Julie's "intersection" to that of, "Vithu," a Cambodian international student attending a US college (on a scholarship) who identifies as Pansexual, and is from a Cambodian Buddhist tradition though has converted to Christianity. The intersection of Vithu's various co-cultures does not include the same power or social privilege as Julie's intersection of being white, middle-class, American, and Christian, all aspects of our dominant culture. However, because Vithu is both a man and now has earned a Ph.D. in Engineering from Harvard University, he may, indeed, jump over Julie in crucial respects of social rank. While not a "competition," these examples show how intersectionality is a dynamic theory that offers insight into how individuals are not easily defined by one culture (or co-culture) even when it dominates.

Samovar's concepts of dominant culture and co-cultures, as well as intersectionality, challenge the validity of assumptions surrounding one's view of co-cultures, whether those of others or one's own. Samovar, et. al. (2017) defines dominant culture as:

Referring to a group of people as a culture...applying the term to the dominant culture found in most societies. In the United States, a variety of terms have been coined to represent this group, such as umbrella culture, mainstream culture, U.S. Americans, and Euro-Americans. We prefer to use dominant culture because it clearly indicates that the group we are referring to generally exercises the greatest influence on the beliefs, values, perceptions, communication patterns, and customs of the culture. A dominant group is characteristic of all cultures, and this collective of people possesses those instruments of power that allow it to set the broad societal agenda the majority of others will commonly follow. The power we are referring to does not necessarily reside in numerical dominance but in the ability to control the major institutions within the culture — governmental, educational, mass media, economic, military, religious, and the like. What a dominant cultural group uses as the basis of power (money, fear, the military, and such) may differ from culture to culture, but in every case, the group determines the political, economic, and social agenda. Regardless of the source of power, certain people within every culture possess and exercise disproportionate influence, and that influence is translated into how other members of the culture shape their lives (pp. 8-9).

Regarding the notion of co-cultures, Samovar et. al. (2017) explains that it is rash to make blanket generalizations and assumptions regarding difference or sameness as members of these groups so often tend to have overlapping memberships:

...within the dominant culture are numerous co-cultures and specialized cultures. We believe the best way to identify these groups is with the term co-culture, because it calls attention to the idea of dual membership. Therefore, we use co-culture when discussing groups or social communities exhibiting perceptions, values, beliefs, communicative behaviors, and social practices that are sufficiently different as to distinguish them from other groups and communities and from the dominant culture. Co-cultures may share many of the characteristics of the dominant culture, but their members also exhibit distinct and unique patterns of communication. Co-cultural affiliation can be based on ethnic heritage, gender, age cohort, sexual preference, or other criteria. What is important about all co-cultures is that being gay, disabled, Latino, African American, Chinese American, American Indian, female, young, or old, to name a few examples, exposes a person to a specialized set of messages that helps determine how some aspects of the external world are perceived. It also significantly influences how members of that co-culture communicate those perceptions (p. 9).

Hence, the vibrant LGBTQ co-culture includes a wide spectrum of members, to a lesser or greater aspect part of the dominant culture, and, as part of the LGBTQ co-culture, range from those who openly share nearly all aspects of themselves and their co-culture to those who still opt for “the closet” or who simply are as yet unsure if they are a member of this group.

Module 5: Improving Intercultural Communication Competence



What can you do to improve your skills, motivation, and knowledge?

Strategies to Use!

OutFront Minnesota Education provides educational training sessions and uses the following materials in the LGBTQ+ 101 & Intersectional Equity Training organized by Kelly Holstine, Director of Education Equity, in entirety, below:

Strategies to Increase Intersectional Equity

- Creating safe, respectful, and caring environments for every learner (help students & educators feel like they matter) & utilizing restorative practices
 - Celebrating vulnerability, sharing authentic selves, and eliminating perspective gaps
 - Advocating for the rights of people who are discriminated against
 - Including diverse voices in the curriculum
 - Engaging in courageous conversations to challenge prejudice and discrimination (including: owning and improving your own flaws and biases [explicit and implicit])

- Letting go of needing to be the “expert” and “in charge” (i.e., being open to asking questions and being curious instead of judgmental)
- Being aware of intention vs. impact
- Breaking down systems that are creating barriers



Equity = giving someone what they need to be successful

Strategies to increase LGBTQ+ Educational Equity

- Adding your pronouns to your email signature
- Not making assumptions when people tell you stories about their lives (e.g., pronouns, sexual orientations, genders, etc.)
- Introducing yourself with affirmed pronouns and using other people’s affirmed pronouns and names
- Using gender inclusive language (e.g., folks, humans, learners, etc.)
- Not gendering students in activities (e.g., having students line up by birthdays or last names instead of by gender identify)
- Speaking out against LGBTQ+ bullying and harassment (i.e., Immediately addressing the use of anti-LGBTQ+ language in schools, standing up for students when they are being discriminated against, etc.)
- Displaying posters and art that represent LGBTQ+ culture (e.g., symbols of support, Safe Space signs).
- Gender Unicorn posters, pictures of LGBTQ+ people, etc.)
- Having safe restroom access (e.g., gender neutral bathrooms, single stall/private bathrooms, supporting students to use whatever bathrooms make them feel safe)
- Recognizing families that are diverse in structure and using inclusive, non-gendered terms (e.g., parents, grown-ups, guardians, caregivers, etc.)
- Including LGBTQ+ voices and examples in the curriculum
- Starting/Supporting Gender Sexuality Alliances (GSAs)
- Supporting laws and policies that support LGBTQ+ humans
- First day with students: read the student’s last name and ask what first name they would like you to use (create rosters with “Student Name” on first line and “Legal name [if different]” on the second line)

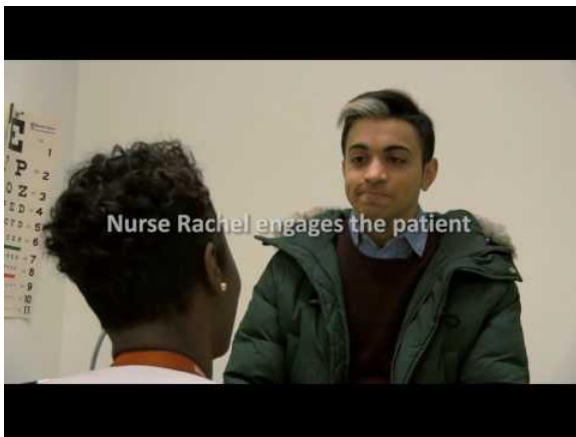
Training Materials

The following videos are useful for training in a number of settings. These training materials are also used in Learning Objects for the class that are not able to be shared in this PressBook, please contact Lori.Halverson-Wente@rctc.edu if you would like access to these.

Training Videos with Medical Scenarios

Care to the Trans* and Gender Non-Conforming Identified Patient

YOUTUBE DESCRIPTION QUOTED HERE: “This video is one in a series created for nursing and healthcare educators for use in a variety of settings.”



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

[Mandala Center for Change](#)

“We Are Here”

YOUTUBE DESCRIPTION QUOTED HERE: “We Are Here” is an educational video focusing on transgender healthcare produced by Mandala Center for Change and Whaleheart Productions. Commissioned by Jefferson Healthcare, this video was a direct outcome of the Mandala Center’s Transgender Youth Legislative Theatre project and is being integrated as required training for local medical providers and support staff. The training video itself is 12 minutes long followed by credits and 3 minutes of Cast Interviews. www.mandalaforchange.com



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

LGBT Healthcare Training Video: “To Treat Me, You Have to Know Who I Am”

YOUTUBE DESCRIPTION QUOTED HERE: “To Treat Me, You Have to Know Who I Am”: New York City Health and Hospitals launched a mandatory employee training program that will improve access to healthcare for lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender (LGBT) individuals and help to reduce health disparities related to sexual orientation and gender identification. The training will teach staff to provide respectful, patient-centered and culturally competent healthcare services to thousands of LGBT New Yorkers who are served by the public hospitals, community health centers and nursing homes every year. Find out more at www.nyc.gov/hhc.



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

youtu.be/qsMxnXyTFc8

Education Related Videos and Resources

YOUTUBE DESCRIPTION QUOTED HERE: The federal law known as Title IX is meant to protect students from discrimination based on their gender identity. But many gay, lesbian, and transgender students say they face an array of challenges and safety issues on their campuses. The Chronicle interviewed more than a dozen of them to hear more about what keeps them from thriving in college.



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

High School

YOUTUBE DESCRIPTION QUOTED HERE: “Imani and Ilayha are speaking out. And Teach For America is proud to support them. We believe that all kids should have access to a safe and affirming school environment. Unfortunately, many don’t right now. Did you know that LGBT youth are more than two times as likely as non-LGBT youth to say they have been verbally harassed, and twice as likely to say they have been physically assaulted, kicked or shoved at school? Worse yet, LGBT youth are more likely than non-LGBT youth to report that they do not have an adult they can talk to about personal problems. Teach For America refuses to let a student’s sexuality limit their opportunities for success. If you agree, speak up by signing and sharing our pledge. Our goal is 25,000 signatures by the time school starts this fall. Show our students that you want them to feel safe at school.”



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

YOUTUBE DESCRIPTION QUOTED HERE: “Meet some of GLSEN’s student ambassadors. These LGBT high school students from across the United States share their experiences and talk about the impact GSAs, Day of Silence, and other GLSEN programs have made on their lives.”



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

The Hetrick-Martin Institute is a non-profit organization that serves the needs of LGBT youth. GLAAD visited their location in downtown New York City and interviewed the LGBT young people about their experiences being bullied.



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

Stories about LGBTQ+ Life Experiences around the World

This Is What LGBT Life Is Like Around the World | Jenni Chang and Lisa Dazols | TED Talks

As a gay couple in San Francisco, Jenni Chang and Lisa Dazols had a relatively easy time living the way they wanted. But outside the bubble of the Bay Area, what was life like for people still lacking basic rights? They set off on a world tour in search of “Supergays,” LGBT people who were doing something extraordinary in the world. In 15 countries across Africa, Asia and South America — from India, recently home to the world’s first openly gay prince, to Argentina, the first country in Latin America to grant marriage equality — they found the inspiring stories and the courageous, resilient and proud Supergays they had been looking for.



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=135

Links to Education Related Topics

- www.chronicle.com/specialreport/Diversity-in-Academe-/11
- <https://www.outfront.org/sites/default/files/OutFront%20LGBTQ%2B%20Resource%20Guide.pdf>
- Toolkit for Ensuring Safe and Supportive Schools for Transgender and Gender Nonconforming Students
 - (9/27/17)Toolkit to help school districts and charter schools create policy/resources for transgender and gender-nonconforming students.
- <https://thesafezoneproject.com/wp-content/uploads/2013/06/SZP-2hr-Curriculum-Facilitator-Guide.pdf>
- https://www.rutgers.international/sites/rutgersorg/files/PDF/web_Rutgers%20GTA%20manual-module1-16.9.18.pdf
- The Effect of LGBT Resource Centers on Student Success & Engagement
- <https://homopoly.eu/module-1-unit-2-coming-out-section-a-when-where-how>
 - **Videos Related to “Coming Out”:**
 1. What LGBT students want you to know <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=B-G4vA6TsX4>
 2. ‘Ask me’: What LGBTQ students want their professors to know <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rmbnF8QAnsY>
 3. Interview with LGBT high schoolers <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=haPXxFLQhJI>
 4. High school senior comes out as LGBT while accepting award https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yILh_jMJv7k
 5. Teacher comes out of the closet with a rap song <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xFJVUV9-zFQ><https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=26rb-IXwbhA>
 6. Morgana Bailey: The danger of hiding who you are (She comes out in her TED Talk) https://www.ted.com/talks/morgana_bailey_the_danger_of_hiding_who_you_are?referrer=playlist-on_coming_out
 7. Geena Rocero: Why I must come out (A Fashion model comes out in her TED Talk) https://www.ted.com/playlists/307/on_coming_out
 8. Elle Mills’ (the maker of fun genre-twisting YouTube videos) coming out story youtu.be/pDi7cez9CA
 9. Coming Out & Dad’s Shocking Confession <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KbDCI5pcpz0>

Module 6:

Finally, Fast Facts, Timelines, and Additional Resources



Dig more deeply, learn more.

This case study area is one where you can gain more access to the communication of individuals of the co-culture, it is not a complete handbook on the co-culture. It can help you, though, to take a more in-depth look at relevant facts, events, and court decisions related to this co-culture. The following links can help you in your research:

- LGBT+ Resources in Minnesota:
 - Advocacy:
 - <https://www.outfront.org/>
 - History:
 - <https://libguides.mnhs.org/lgbtqrightrights>
 - Legal Rights in Minnesota:
 - <https://mn.gov/law-library/legal-topics/lgbt-rights.jsp>
 - Demographics:
 - <https://williamsinstitute.law.ucla.edu/visualization/lgbt-stats/?topic=LGBT&area=27#density>
- PewResearch:
 - <https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2017/06/13/5-key-findings-about-lgbt-americans/>
- Timeline:
 - <https://www.cnn.com/2015/06/19/us/lgbt-rights-milestones-fast-facts/index.html>
- Additional Links of Interest
 - “When The Conversation Doesn’t Include You: LGBTQ+ Sex Ed In A Small Town” – NPR Podcast
<https://www.npr.org/2019/04/01/706944327/when-the-conversation-doesnt-include-you-lgbtq-sex-ed-in-a-small-town>

Works Cited

(*under construction)

Adult health. (2019, August 21). Retrieved May 1, 2020, from www.mayoclinic.org/healthy-living/hlv-20049421

Open Textbook Library. (2016). *Communication in the Real World: An Introduction to Communication Studies*. Minneapolis, MN.

Legal & Trans Justice. (n.d.). Retrieved May 1, 2020, from <https://www.outfront.org/legal-trans-ans-law-health>

Liszewski, W., Peebles, J. K., Yeung, H., & Arron, S. (2018, December 20). Persons of Nonbinary Gender – Awareness, Visibility, and Health Disparities. Retrieved May 1, 2020, from www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC6748626/

McLean, S. (2018). *Intercultural Communication*. Boston: Flat World.

National Center for Transgender Equality. (n.d.). Retrieved May 23, 2020, from <https://transequality.org/sites/default/files/mary-Dec17.pdf>

Originally published on 22 January, 2016. (2020, April 28). Do Ask, Do Tell: Talking to your provider about being LGBT ” LGBT Health Education Center. Retrieved from <http://www.lgbthealtheducation.org/publication/dadt/>

Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Caregivers in the LGBT Community. (n.d.). Retrieved May 1, 2020, from <https://www.aarp.org/content/dam/aar...lgbt-aarp.pdf>

Reid-Smith, T. (2020, January 24). Should I use LGBT, LGBTQ, LGBTI, LGBTQIA or something else? Retrieved May 1, 2020, from <https://www.gaystarnews.com/article/...omething-else/>

Samovar, L. A., Porter, R. E., McDaniel, E. R., & Roy, C. S. (2017). *Communication between cultures*. Boston, MA: Cengage Learning.

This page titled [3.1: Guest 1 – Meet Michael and Learn about the LGBTQ+ Community](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente \(Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project\)](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

3.2: Guest 2 – Meet Meet Kim Sin and learn about the Cambodian-American Community

Meet Kim Sin



Kim Sin, an RCTC alum and former employee, is an active Rochester, MN resident who survived a harrowing escape from the Khmer Rouge Genocide. Kim and Lori Halverson-Wente, along with their spouses, led an RCTC International Service Learning Trip to Cambodia for 8 years.

Kim shares his story of survival, persistence, and success in many venues. As a Human Library “Book,” he describes his family’s experience as an immigrant. He has led numerous community initiatives and is currently employed at the University of MN, Rochester in the IT department. He leads, “The Community” “Kim Sin was born in Tak To, Cambodia in 1977. He started the Cambodian Association of Rochester, Minnesota. SUBJECTS DISCUSSED: Early life in Cambodia and family – living in Cambodia during the Khmer Rouge War – living in a refugee camp – coming to Minnesota – adjusting to living in Minnesota as a child – being behind in school – starting the Cambodian Association of Rochester, Minnesota (CARM) – involvement in the community and assimilating – never quite being treated as an American – accepting his own identity – future generations of children coming to Minnesota – starting a non-profit organization – helping out all people, not just certain groups – judging people fairly” (<https://immigrants.mndigital.org/items/show/122>)

Listen To Kim’s Story

Please listen – <https://immigrants.mndigital.org/items/show/122>

Please Read: [Transcript of Kim Sin’s story to the Minnesota Historical Society](#)

Lori Interviews Kim Sin



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=138

Cambodia Service Learning Trip Past Video

youtu.be/MHyb2qMXu1o

Wouldn't you like to Join Us?

Kim, Dara, Morgan, and Lori Reflect upon the Service Trip and Demonstrate how ZOOM Virtual Speaker's Series can Work. If you chose this option for a ZOOM session, you will meet and chat with Kim Sin, past participants from the volunteer experience, and Cambodian students "live from Cambodia."

Of course, each ZOOM session will be unique to the folks who are available at the time, but this is a sample of a recent conversation we had to simulate a ZOOM session.



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=138

Kim Sin's Current Volunteer Project you can Join!

One way you can gain more experience in intercultural communication is to join Kim Sin and others at the Community Garden he has organized and leads.



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=138

This page titled [3.2: Guest 2 – Meet Meet Kim Sin and learn about the Cambodian-American Community](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente](#) ([Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project](#)) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

3.3: Guest 3 – Meet Al Lun and Learn more about being a “Permanent Other”



Meet Al Lun

The following bio, from Al's webpage, shares Al Lun's interests. Please visit his amazing website that keeps up with local communication surrounding community events, local resources, and data analysis of all sorts: <http://dmcbeam.org/about-us>

“Retired from IBM, Al Lun has worked in the computer industry for over 3 decades. He has worked in technology development in various capacities including architecture, project management, software/hardware development, and people management.

*Active in Rochester-area philanthropic boards, Al is also building out the [Community Beam](#) website **to co-create a healthy and inclusive community where opportunity and responsibility are broadly shared***

He believes in the 4P principle of running an organization: People, Process, Product, Profit, in that order. And people must be first.”

More about Al:

Mr. Lun is a regular volunteer in the COMM 2100 classroom but, even more so, he helps lead efforts at the YMCA and Diversity Council. Sharing a conversation with Al will help you see his intercultural communication experiences throughout his career and personal life. His insight is profound and we all learn so much each time he shares. His Human Library “Book” is entitled, “Permanent Other.” Students from past classes share that they never knew that someone would be “caught between cultures,” and, even after 40 years living in Rochester, MN, would be asked, “But where are you REALLY from?”

[Listen to Al share his insight, then consider an intercultural conversation with Al!](#)

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Sa-kEsZCoKE&t=15s>

Chatting with Al, you'll always have a local contact who has navigated globalization in the workplace from his lifelong successful career as an Engineer at IBM, along with a keen understanding of local happenings!

This page titled [3.3: Guest 3 – Meet Al Lun and Learn more about being a “Permanent Other”](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente \(Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project\)](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

3.4: Guest 3 – Meet Chao Mwatela, RCTC Multicultural Advisor



Meet Chao

Chao Mwatela, RCTC's Multicultural Advisor shares with students an invitation to learn more about her role on campus in the areas of Equity and Inclusion. You might also want to chat with Ms. Mwatela as an advisor or if you are just having a tough day! Here is her RCTC bio from the college's Equity and Diversity webpage (<https://www.rctc.edu/services/student...>)

“Chao Mwatela was born in Kenya, East Africa. As a second child in a large family, she learned to be independent and outspoken at an early age and attended boarding school during her high school years.

“ The years of boarding school, plus an adventurous spirit made the choice of attending college abroad an easy one. Chao attended college at the University of Arkansas at Pine Bluff where she received a Bachelor of Science Degree in Fisheries Biology. “Chao has been hooked on the field of education since her first job right out of college as a high school science teacher. She has since worked as a Special Education educator, a high school science teacher, a college laboratory assistant, and currently as a multicultural advisor at Rochester Community and Technical College. She also believes in life-long education and is currently completing her Master's Degree at Winona State University in Organizational Leadership, as well as a Graduate Certificate in Multicultural Education.

“Chao is passionate about equity, particularly in education. When Chao is not at RCTC working with students or on diversity-related initiatives, you will probably find her with her independent and outspoken daughter 💎💎 ... or with her nose in a book” (RCTC, 2020).



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=144

[More about Chao Mwatela](#)



A Vimeo element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=144

This page titled [3.4: Guest 3 – Meet Chao Mwatela, RCTC Multicultural Advisor](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente](#) ([Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project](#)) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

3.5: Guest 4 – Meet Becca, RCTC Director of Student Rights and Responsibilities/Title IX Coordinator

Meet Becca Peine



Director of Student Rights and Responsibilities/Title IX Coordinator

Rebecca Peine

Office: CC401

Phone: 507-285-7195

E-mail: rebecca.peine@rctc.edu

Contact Becca if you'd like to have more information on any of the topics she shares in this video. Becca shares more about her role on campus and how students can gain access to the services she provides. She is an active community volunteer in the areas of Equity and Inclusion. She also is a proud aunt, sews masks for charitable fundraising during COVID-19, and is known to bring energy and cheer to all committees she serves on!



A YouTube element has been excluded from this version of the text. You can view it online here: pb.libretexts.org/developinginter/?p=147

This page titled [3.5: Guest 4 – Meet Becca, RCTC Director of Student Rights and Responsibilities/Title IX Coordinator](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente](#) (Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

3.6: Guest 5 – Meet Laura, RCTC Student and Human Library Volunteer



Meet Laura

Laura Oakgrove speaks regularly to the COMM 2100 class. As an RCTC student, she has assisted as a Teaching Assistant in the class, having taken the class. After attending the Human Library as a student for her “Intercultural Communication Conversations/Site Visits,” she immediately signed up as Human Library Volunteer and is a leader in the community in this effort. Laura shares her life stories of, “Walking in Darkness,” as she explains what it is like to lose her sight. Laura offers “readers” the choice of stories concerning her lived experience as a woman who grew up on the Red Lake Reservation in northern Minnesota, “Native.” Additionally, she opens the door to a frank discussion about living in poverty, raising her 3 children as a single mother going to school to better her own life through her “book” called, “Fixed Income.”

As an RCTC student, Laura offers practical advice for students to adopt a more inclusive communication style right here, right now in your own backyard and school. Please reach out to Lori if you’d like to participate in an Intercultural Conversation Showcase with Laura.

<https://youtube.com/watch?v=dRGjdeZJ...wmode%3Dopaque>

<https://kttc.com/2019/12/03/rocheste...all-abilities/>

NewsReport; <https://kttc.com/2019/12/03/rochester-community-celebrates-all-abilities/>

Additional Resources Laura Suggests reading:

Red Lake Nation Information:

<https://www.redlakenation.org/>

Warrior Nation: A History of the Red Lake Ojibwe, Anton Treuer

“The Red Lake Nation has a unique and deeply important history. Unlike every other reservation in Minnesota, Red Lake holds its land in common—and, consequently, the tribe retains its entire reservation land base. The people of Red Lake developed the first modern indigenous democratic governance system in the United States, decades before any other tribe, but they also maintained their system of hereditary chiefs. The tribe never surrendered to state jurisdiction over crimes committed on its reservation. The reservation is also home to the highest number of Ojibwe-speaking people in the state.”

Warrior Nation covers four centuries of the Red Lake Nation’s forceful and assertive tenure on its land. Ojibwe historian and linguist Anton Treuer conducted oral histories with elders across the Red Lake reservation, learning the stories carried by the people. And the Red Lake band has, for the first time, made available its archival collections, including the personal papers of Peter Graves, the brilliant political strategist and tribal leader of the first half of the twentieth century, which tell a startling story about the negotiations over reservation boundaries.

This fascinating history offers not only a chronicle of the Red Lake Nation but also a compelling perspective on a difficult piece of U.S. history” (from Book Bio).

Also, See:

[Summary of the Book and a highlighting article by Anton Treuer](#)

[News Report on, Anton Treuer, Author](#)

This page titled [3.6: Guest 5 – Meet Laura, RCTC Student and Human Library Volunteer](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lori Halverson-Wente and Mark Halverson-Wente \(Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project\)](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

Index

D

dire

Glossary

Sample Word 1 | Sample Definition 1

Detailed Licensing

Overview

Title: [Developing Intercultural Communication Competence \(Halverson-Wente and Halverson-Wente\)](#)

Webpages: 30

Applicable Restrictions: Noncommercial

All licenses found:

- [CC BY-NC 4.0](#): 86.7% (26 pages)
- [Public Domain](#): 10% (3 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 3.3% (1 page)

By Page

- [Developing Intercultural Communication Competence \(Halverson-Wente and Halverson-Wente\)](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Introduction](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [1: Intercultural Communication](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [1.1: Key Intercultural Communication Terms](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [1.2: Intercultural Communication and Cultural Relativism](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [1.3: Perception](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [1.4: Nonverbal Communication](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [1.5: Verbal Communication](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [1.6: Listening](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [2: Intercultural Communication Interview Essay](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [2.1: Sample Essays](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [2.2: Grading Rubric](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [2.3: Sample Outline 1 – Exploring 3 Different Aspects of a Co-Culture](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [2.4: Sample Outline 2](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [3: Communicating with Co-Cultures](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [3.1: Guest 1 – Meet Michael and Learn about the LGBTQA+ Community](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [3.2: Guest 2 – Meet Meet Kim Sin and learn about the Cambodian-American Community](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [3.3: Guest 3 – Meet Al Lun and Learn more about being a “Permanent Other”](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [3.4: Guest 3 – Meet Chao Mwatela, RCTC Multicultural Advisor](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [3.6: Guest 5 – Meet Laura, RCTC Student and Human Library Volunteer](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [3.5: Guest 4 – Meet Becca, RCTC Director of Student Rights and Responsibilities/Title IX Coordinator](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [Back Matter](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)